

A HOTPAST STORY

I KNOW WHO YOU DID LAST SUMMER

BOOK 3



BESTSELLING AUTHOR
PAUL GARLAND

I KNOW WHO YOU DID LAST SUMMER, BOOK 3

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CERULEAN EROTICA

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CONTENTS

[I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 3](#)

[1. Chapter 1](#)

[2. Chapter 2](#)

[3. Chapter 3](#)

[4. Chapter 4](#)

[5. Chapter 5](#)

[6. Chapter 6](#)

[7. Chapter 7](#)

[Afterword](#)

[Also by Paul Garland](#)

[About The Author](#)

[Find Me On Social Media](#)

I KNOW WHO YOU DID LAST SUMMER, BOOK 3

Ryan thought he knew everything about his wife, Emmie. But as the secrets she's kept hidden from their year apart threaten to destroy everything they've built together, he also has to find a way of dealing with his own guilt.

Amid mounting tension, old friends, and the arrival of new faces, Ryan is pulled deeper into a web of lies, betrayal, and desire. With the mysterious emailer holding the key to Emmie's darkest secrets, Ryan must decide whether he can handle the truth—or if it's a price too high to pay.

As passions rise and the line between love and betrayal blurs, Ryan must face the ultimate question: Can he truly forgive Emmie for what she's done? Or will their fractured relationship be lost forever?

In this gripping third installment of the *I Know Who You Did Last Summer* series, nothing is as it seems, and the truth might just be the most dangerous thing of all.

'I Know Who You Did Last Summer, Book 3' is a hotpast erotica story featuring explicit adult scenes and explores themes such as cuckolding, hotwife and wife-sharing.

CHAPTER ONE

The house was silent around me, a heavy stillness settling in as I sat on the edge of the sofa, phone clutched tightly in my hand. Emmie was still at her work meeting with Nate and his unexpected guests. My finger hovered over the play button, the familiar pang of dread and curiosity curling in my stomach. The final video. But not the only video. The email's words swirled in my mind.

The events of tonight have changed things.

I tried to make sense of that cryptic line, but the relentless need to know, to understand, was all I could feel.

Just press play, I told myself, forcing down the churning guilt that was still fresh from my encounter with Laura.

I should leave this well alone. Delete the video. Ignore any future emails. I should tell Emmie everything. Come clean. Put this behind us.

My finger pressed the screen, and the video began.

The image flickered to life, instantly pulling me in. Emmie was there, just as the thumbnail had shown — kneeling on the bed, her bare skin bathed in the low, dim light of the room. Her wavy blonde hair fell around her shoulders, framing her face as she looked over her shoulder, a small, provocative smile on her lips. I felt a familiar mix of emotions — arousal, anger, a strange fascination that wouldn't let me look away.

Then he appeared in the frame: the man from the previous video, only his lower body, his face hidden from view. He moved behind her, one hand

settling firmly on her hips as he positioned his long, hard cock, still wet with her saliva at the smooth, shaven entrance to her pussy. Emmie's eyes closed, her expression melting into one of pure pleasure as he pressed forward, and this time the video didn't stop there.

He entered her in a single, smooth thrust. It was gut-wrenching to see another man's cock slide into my wife's pussy but I couldn't stop watching. He pulled out slightly, then shoved it in again and even without the audio, I could feel the intensity of it, the way her body arched, meeting him eagerly.

My hands tightened on the phone and the muscles in my jaw clenched as I watched. He was both longer and thicker than me but Emmie's pussy took him easily. She looked away, down at the bed, his movements confident as he took her from behind, thrusting into her with a roughness that sent her body rocking forward, her breasts bouncing outwards slightly with each thrust.

I couldn't believe what I was witnessing, even though I knew what I would see when I pressed the play button. The angle of the camera was such that I could see every detail of his cock pushing into my wife's pussy, stretching out her pink folds with every deep thrust. Then she tipped her head back, her hair falling onto her face but not enough to stop me from seeing that her mouth was open, her eyes closed, enjoying the sensation of this thick, long shaft driving into her.

My heart raced, the images burning into my mind. How could she enjoy it like that with another man? She looked like she'd forgotten about me like I was the last thing on her mind during that moment. She was savouring every moment of being fucked, hard and rough, by this new man, whoever he was.

My own dick twitched in my shorts, stiffening even though I'd cum with Laura only a short time ago. I hated that this was arousing me, that I could feel that familiar ache in my gut, the same hard-to-understand pull that had kept me glued to every clip that had come before. My mind was a mess, a tangled knot of jealousy and desire, each warring with the other.

The man's movements grew more intense, his hand sliding over her back, gripping her shoulders as he pulled her closer, driving into her harder. And then just when I thought the scene couldn't get any more overwhelming, he shifted, pulling her, flipping her onto her back. Emmie lay there, her large breasts rising and falling as she looked up at him, her legs wrapping around

his waist as he entered her again, balls deep, his body grinding against hers, fully impaled inside my wife.

I forced myself to keep watching, even as something inside me unravelled painfully, a feeling like I was coming undone. But then... something strange happened. The camera, which had kept the same point-of-view the entire time, suddenly shifted, moving slightly to the left, and that's when I noticed it. I could see both of his hands. My heart stopped.

Someone else was filming.

The realisation hit me like a punch to the gut. My pulse raced, my breath catching as I tried to understand it. I'd assumed the man with Emmie was the one recording, but... this changed everything. Who was holding the camera? Who was watching? Who was recording?

As the cameraman or woman stepped back slightly, more of the man fucking Emmie came into view, but still not enough to reveal his identity. He looked tall and muscular but without seeing him above the middle of his body, it wasn't enough to reveal who he was. He continued thrusting into her, his hands sliding over her breasts, cupping them and enjoying their largeness, their firmness, just as I enjoyed doing when we had sex this way.

It felt surreal to see my wife with another man, even if this had taken place while we weren't together, and I couldn't help but watch with fascination as she suddenly arched her back. Her fingers tangled in the bed sheets below us and while there was no sound on the video, I could imagine the moan that erupted from her open lips as she came. The man pulled his cock from her for a moment, slick with her wetness, waiting until her body relaxed, her legs finished quivering, and then he pushed it back in.

Emmie looked up at him, her hazel eyes wide, her cheeks flushed and then she smiled as his hips began to move faster, ramming his cock into her shaved pussy harder, his movements becoming frenzied, his pace increasing. I could see the tension rising in his body now, the way he pulled her onto him, his grip tightening on her hips as he buried himself savagely inside her one last time, making her appear to cry out.

Then he pulled out, stroking himself a few times before releasing, his cum shooting out from his throbbing erection, splashing over her belly, some reaching her chest, her skin gleaming as it dripped down between her breasts.

And then, just as suddenly as it had moved before, the camera shifted again, tilting downwards. The video jolted slightly, and I caught a glimpse

of something — the floor, the edge of someone's shoe, maybe? — before the image went dark, the screen faded back to black.

I sat there, staring at the phone, my mind racing—the implications of what I'd just seen washed over me like a cold wave. Emmie hadn't just been with this man — someone else had been there the whole time. Watching them, filming them. What happened next? Had the other guy — if it was a guy — taken over? Had he fucked my wife too? Or had he just been there to watch and record it?

More questions piled up, the weight of them pressing down on me, each one more disturbing than the last until I reached the ultimate question. Whoever these people were, why the hell were they sending me these videos and why now? What did they want?

I took a shaky breath, closing my eyes as I tried to calm the storm raging inside me. Ever since those condoms fell out of Emmie's coat, ever since I'd started this journey to find the truth, every answer I thought I'd found had only led to more questions, and now... now I was drowning in them. I need to know the truth, I thought, a sense of resolve settling over me. But how?

Meet me next week. I'll send you a date, time, and place.

The final line of the email echoed in my mind. Did I wait for the emailer to get in touch and get my answers that way? What if they intended to split Emmie and me up? Letting them be in control wasn't working. I couldn't stand the fact that someone was out there, pulling the strings like this.

Should I take the bull by the horns instead and confront Emmie tonight? If I did that, she might shut the entire thing down. She could contact the sender and tell them to stop. She could force them to delete the other videos. She might even contact the police, killing any chance I had of learning the whole truth — not just Emmie's inevitably watered-down version. And I'd never see the other videos that the emailer spoke of.

Or did I take this to Jen or someone who might be able to shed some light on things? Of course, Jen knew more than she was letting on. Why had she wanted to speak to Emmie tonight? Was it somehow connected to me getting the email just now? But how did I bring this up without Jen running straight to Emmie? They were already working together to hide things from me. Jen and Emmie were close. She'd never prioritise me over her sister.

I'd come this far, let myself be dragged deeper and deeper into Emmie's past. I couldn't turn back now. I was so close to the truth. Whoever this was,

whatever they knew — I was going to find out, but I couldn't let it tear my world apart. Emmie meant everything to me, even though I was discovering there was a side to her that she'd kept hidden this past year.

I needed to do something. Sitting here in the empty house was making me feel like I was losing my grip. I glanced at the time on my phone — a little past 9.00 PM. Emmie's meeting should be finished soon, surely. Maybe I could just talk to her, hear her voice. That would ground me. I brought up her number on my phone, tapping the call button impatiently, but it rang out without an answer. I gritted my teeth. She was probably busy in her meeting, of course, but I couldn't shake the unease gnawing at me.

She's fine, I told myself. She's just working. But I didn't believe it. Not entirely. Not after what I'd just seen.

An idea struck me, and I scrolled through my contacts again, landing on Jen's name. She'd said she'd been trying to reach Emmie earlier. Maybe she'd had better luck than me. I hit the call button and pressed the phone to my ear, the tension in my chest building with each unanswered ring until finally, she picked up.

"Hey, Ryan," Jen's voice was much more relaxed than it had been earlier. "Don't worry. I managed to get hold of her and everything's fine."

I took a breath, forcing a calm I didn't feel. "Ah, thanks, Jen. That's good to know. I, uh, I tried calling her just now, but she didn't pick up."

"Oh, yeah?" Jen replied. "I wouldn't worry. You were right. When I called earlier, she was in a meeting with Nate and some clients. They were having dinner in some restaurant or other, so I'm sure she's probably just busy and will ring you back when she can."

Relief mixed with the lingering tension in my gut. At least she was where she was supposed to be. "Yeah, I guess," I replied, my voice tighter than intended.

"Are you sure you're okay, Ryan? You don't sound great."

I hesitated, my fingers tightening around the phone. This was why I'd decided to call her conventionally rather than the video calling method she'd chosen earlier. I was worried that Jen would be able to see the worry on my face.

"I'm fine. Just a long day, that's all. You're right, she'll probably call me back in a minute. And if she doesn't, I'll try her again later."

There was a pause, and I could sense Jen's unease. "Alright," she said finally. "If you're sure, but look... if you need to talk... about anything..."

you know you can call me, right?”

“Yeah, thanks,” I said, my voice clipped. “I’m fine. Really. Goodnight, Jen.”

I ended the call before she could press further, dropping the phone onto the sofa beside me. I wasn’t fine. Far from it. My mind was spinning, the questions and doubts swirling together in an endless loop. Emmie had let someone film her having sex. That alone was enough to mess with my head, but the possibility of a threesome? Or worse, that this was just one of many such encounters? One thing I’d realised since watching the video is that none of the meet-ups that Laura had described were when the video had been recorded. So that was a separate night — a separate hook-up — to the other three. It felt like my world was shifting beneath me.

I couldn’t stay here. The walls of the house felt too close, the silence too loud. I needed air, movement — anything to stop the chaotic mess of thoughts in my head. I grabbed my keys and headed out, the cold hitting me as I stepped outside into the damp, autumnal night air.

I got into the car, the engine humming to life, and started driving with no real destination in mind, letting the empty streets guide me. The faint glow of streetlights reflected on the wet pavement as I drove, my thoughts still racing. After a few minutes, I suddenly realised where I was headed.

Without thinking, I found myself heading toward the Dolphin, the restaurant where Nate and Emmie often had their meetings or took clients. She’d mentioned to me a few times and told me how nice it was. I’d never been there myself but I knew where it was, not too far, I’d driven by it countless times. Maybe... maybe I’d see Emmie there. Maybe seeing her would give me some clarity.

The idea was ridiculous, I knew that, but it was my subconscious that had led me here. Perhaps I should listen to it, and trust my gut. Plus, I couldn’t turn back now. Not when my mind was spiralling out of control. I needed something, anything, to anchor me.

The Dolphin came into view, its warm, golden lights spilling out onto the street. The building was an old place, built from stone in the traditional shape of a pub but had been transformed into a swanky, modern restaurant. Its car park was half full, a mix of high-end sports cars and more modest cars like mine. I pulled in and parked at the far edge, out of sight of the main entrance. My heart pounded as I sat there, staring at the building.

What was I even hoping to see? Emmie working with her current boss, Nate, Mitch and her old boss, Ethan? A casual dinner meeting? Or something more damning, something that would only feed the paranoia clawing at me?

I turned off the engine, the silence inside the car deafening. I had no plan, no idea what I was doing here. But I couldn't leave. Not yet.

Taking a deep breath, I scanned the car park, my eyes darting between the windows of the restaurant and the vehicles around me. Did I get out of the car and walk into the restaurant, to see if I could find her? No. That would make me look like some sort of crazy stalker. What was I even doing here? I was behaving like a crazy stalker, truth be told.

I was just about to turn on the engine again and head home when my phone buzzed on the passenger seat. The screen lit up with Emmie's name. My chest tightened as I snatched it up, hesitating for just a second before answering.

"Hey," I said, forcing my voice to sound casual.

"Hi, babe," she replied, her tone light and cheerful, but I could hear the faint hum of background noise — dishes clinking and muffled voices. "Just wanted to let you know I'm about to leave. The meeting's done, and I should be home shortly."

"Oh, okay," I said, my mind racing as I stared at the glowing sign of the restaurant in front of me. "I, uh, just popped out to the shop to grab a couple of things. You might beat me home."

There was a pause, just long enough to make my heart skip a beat. Why was I lying? Why couldn't I just tell her I was out for a drive? Or even admit I was outside the restaurant? Something in my gut told me not to.

"No problem," Emmie said finally, her voice easy, unbothered. "See you soon."

"Yeah, see you soon," I replied, ending the call before she could ask anything else. My hand was shaking slightly as I set the phone back down.

I stared at the restaurant for a few more moments before starting the car and pulling out of the lot. I couldn't leave, not yet, but I didn't want to be sitting in plain sight either. My instincts told me to stay, to wait, even if I wasn't sure what I was waiting for.

I parked just around the corner, pulling into a shadowed spot where I could still see the entrance. My heart thudded in my chest as I killed the

engine and leaned back, trying to look inconspicuous. Minutes passed, each one stretching longer than the last.

And then I saw them.

Emmie emerged first, her wavy blonde hair catching the soft glow of the restaurant's lights. She looked... gorgeous, at ease. Like she was in her element, laughing softly at something one of the men behind her said. I sucked in a breath as Nate stepped out next to her, his athletic frame catching the light. I'd seen him before, blond-haired, confident — too confident for such a young man, and with the kind of grin that made you want to punch someone just for having it.

Behind them came Ethan, her previous boss, tall and distinguished, his sharp grey hair glinting in the light. His arm was draped casually around the waist of a tall woman with mocha skin and flowing black locks — striking, glamorous, her beauty obvious even from where I was sitting, some distance away. Something about her tugged at my memory again. I'd seen her before somewhere but I couldn't place it right now.

And then Mitch. Mitchell fucking Davison. Dark-haired, and imposing, his broad shoulders cutting a sharp silhouette as he stepped into the group. He looked calm and composed, but there was an intensity about him, a quiet command that made it hard to look away.

The four of them, plus Ethan's beautiful but familiar companion, stood together for a moment, exchanging a few more words before starting toward the car park. My breath caught as I watched Emmie laugh at something Nate said, her hand brushing his arm lightly. Mitch said something next, and her laughter bubbled up again, softer this time but no less genuine.

My chest tightened as I took them in. Ethan's grey hair, Nate's athletic build, Mitch's dark, commanding presence... wait, it couldn't be... could it? They fit the descriptions Laura had given me too perfectly. The silver fox, the blond athlete, the broad-shouldered, dark-haired man. My mind reeled. Were these the three men Laura saw? The ones Emmie had been with during our break?

And if they were, what did that mean for tonight? What did it mean for the cryptic email and the promise of more videos?

As the group moved toward their cars, I couldn't shake the feeling that I was staring at something I wasn't meant to see. Ethan's companion's laugh rang out, her voice soft but carrying in the still night air. I glanced at her

again, that nagging sense of familiarity growing stronger. Who was she? Where had I seen her before? She gave me the same sense of familiarity as Natasha, I realised.

I watched as Emmie stopped for a moment, holding up her phone and taking a selfie. A second later, my phone buzzed on the car seat and I picked it up, staring at the photo she'd sent, her face with the restaurant in the background.

We had dinner at the Dolphin, the message below it read. I missed you tonight. I love you.

The group began dispersing, heading to their cars. Emmie climbed into Nate's sleek convertible, her laughter fading as the door closed behind her. Mitch's dark sports car rumbled to life, followed by Ethan's SUV. The glamorous stranger climbed in with Ethan, her long legs disappearing into the passenger seat as he started the engine.

I stayed where I was, watching as they all drove off in different directions. My heart was pounding, my mind racing. For some reason, this didn't feel like it was just a work meeting.

What the hell was going on?

CHAPTER TWO

I followed Nate's convertible, keeping a steady distance, far enough to avoid suspicion but close enough not to lose them. Emmie's laughter still echoed in my ears, the sight of her with those three men swirling in my mind. Ethan's sleek SUV and Mitch's sedan had already driven off in the other direction. I gripped the steering wheel tighter, my palms slick with sweat as I drove, realising he wasn't heading back to the office for Emmie to get her car. He was taking her straight to our home.

A short time later, he slowed, coming to a halt in front of the house. Emmie stepped out, her heels clicking softly against the pavement. Nate leaned across the passenger seat, saying something that made her laugh again. She tucked her long, blonde hair behind her ear, smiling in a way that felt too... easy. Too intimate. She waved, shutting the car door before heading up the drive.

Nate lingered for a moment, his eyes following her as she approached the house. Only when she unlocked the door and disappeared inside did he finally pull away, the low purr of his engine fading into the distance.

I pulled up outside but stayed in my car, heart hammering as I watched the house. The light in the living room flicked on, illuminating Emmie's familiar silhouette as she moved through the space. She looked relaxed, like it had been just another night. Like she hadn't been laughing with Mitch, Nate, and Ethan at some posh restaurant while I sat here, stewing in my suspicions.

Had it really just been a work meeting? If so, why the fuck were Mitch and Ethan there?

Taking a deep breath, I stepped out of the car, quietly closing the door behind me. The cool night air did little to calm my nerves as I approached the house, my feet kicking through the deep carpet of fallen leaves that had swept in the wind to almost block the path.

Inside, I found her in the kitchen, pulling a bottle of water from the fridge. She looked up when she heard the door shut behind me, her lips curving into a soft smile and her pretty, hazel eyes glowing softly in the light. “Hey, babe,” she said, twisting the cap off and taking a sip. “I didn’t hear you come in. Did you get what you wanted?”

The question hit me like a slap. Shit. My mind raced, trying to come up with an answer. My heart pounded, each beat mocking me for not thinking ahead. “Oh, uh...” I hesitated, running a hand through my hair. “They didn’t have what I needed, so I didn’t bother getting anything.”

Her brows furrowed slightly. “What were you after?”

“Just, um... some stuff for breakfast tomorrow. Cereal or something, you know. I thought we were running low.” I forced a casual shrug, hoping it sounded convincing.

She tilted her head, studying me for a moment, then smiled. “Well, you should’ve called me. I could’ve picked something up on my way back.” She turned, placing the water bottle on the counter. “Nate dropped me off since I left my car at the office. I figured I might as well have a drink, and he was heading this way anyway.”

My chest tightened. So that explained why she’d been with Nate.

“Sounds like a nice evening,” I said as Emmie leaned against the counter, sipping her water. I tried to keep my tone casual. “So why were Ethan and Mitch at the meeting? That seems kind of weird.”

She tilted her head slightly, thinking. “It was a little, kind of. Mitch is looking at some sort of joint venture with Nate, something to do with his business clients and our marketing strategies. Ethan was there because he’s advising Mitch on some of the numbers, I think. You know, big boys playing with big money — completely over my head, honestly.” She shrugged, smiling faintly. “I just had to sit there and nod like I knew what was going on.”

I nodded, trying to appear satisfied with her explanation, but my mind was still spinning. Emmie didn’t seem fazed, though, and her expression

brightened slightly. “Anyway, Ethan’s latest girlfriend was the highlight of the evening. You’d have loved her, Ry. She’s ridiculously gorgeous — tall, dark, legs for days and that hair! She looks like she’s stepped straight off the pages of Vogue or something. Apparently, she used to be a model full-time, but she’s, um... doing something else now.” Emmie giggled, for some reason. “Anyway, honestly, standing next to her made me feel like a potato.”

The casual mention of Ethan’s girlfriend sent a ripple through me. That mocha-skinned beauty with the jet-black hair. The one who had seemed so familiar, but from where? From modelling? I frowned, wondering if that was where I’d seen her before, on the pages of a magazine or billboard.

“You’re far from a potato,” I said, managing a weak smile while I wracked my brain. “I’m sure you were the most beautiful woman in the restaurant.”

She rolled her eyes, but her smile softened. “You’re sweet, but I know my place.”

“Stop it,” I berated her. “She can’t have been prettier than you. I won’t believe it, even if she was a model. You could be a model. I’ve always said you’re good-looking enough.”

“Hmm.” She took another sip of water, looking down at her body. The navy-blue material of the dress she wore clung to her curves, the modestly-cut top still showing a hint of cleavage. “I’m not slim or tall enough. And these boobs are too big.”

“There’s no such thing as boobs that are too big,” I chuckled. “So you said she used to be a model. What’s she doing now? How did Ethan meet her?”

“Ethan’s a ladies’ man,” Emmie reminded me, her gaze shifting slightly. “Always was. He’s always hooking up with beautiful young women, impressed by his wealth. He’ll soon get tired of this latest one, Charlotte. Which is a shame, because she seems sweet.” Her voice lowered, becoming almost conspiratorial. “Even if she is an OnlyFans model now.”

“An OnlyFans model?” I repeated, my eyebrows lifting. I hadn’t expected that.

“Apparently, she makes several grand a month,” Emmie nodded, her eyes meeting mine for a moment. “But... selling her body like that... Not something I could ever do, even if I had a body like hers. No, I think I’ll stick to what I’m good at.”

“What?” I stroked my chin, trying to act casual. “Why? Did she suggest you do it?”

“No,” she giggled. “But maybe Ethan did. He does have a history of dating these sorts of girls. Nude models and the like.”

“You’re joking,” I gasped, my heart thudding in my chest. “Ethan suggested you do nude modelling?”

“Of course I’m joking,” she laughed, walking over and punching me playfully in the arm. “If he suggested anything that, I’d kick him square in the balls.”

“Right.” I was confused. This was all too much. I was struggling to keep up. I had so much to think about, and that was without even reconciling the fact that I’d fucked Laura earlier.

“Oh, and don’t worry about Mitch,” Emmie added, her tone light and dismissive as she wandered to the foot of the stairs. “He mentioned you’re taking over his account and said he’s looking forward to working with you again. He actually spoke really highly of you. Said you’re one of the most professional guys he’s ever dealt with.”

I blinked, caught off guard yet again by the sudden praise from Mitch of all people. That wasn’t the Mitch I remembered from school, but maybe people really did change — or maybe Mitch had just figured out how to charm people professionally.

Emmie put her foot on the bottom step. “I’m beat. I’m going to head upstairs, relax a bit, maybe read before bed.” She hesitated just a moment, her lips curling into a teasing grin. “You can, uh, check out Charlotte online if you want to know more. Charlotte Andino, I think she said her name was. Just don’t enjoy yourself too much. ”

“You want me to check out your old boss’s girlfriend?” I said, my voice a mixture of disbelief and amusement. “If she’s hot, I might have to sign up for her OnlyFans and — ”

“Don’t even think about it. I think she’s making enough money already. Don’t be too late coming up,” she interrupted, cutting me off with a soft laugh as she turned to leave. Her heels clicked against the wooden steps as she made her way upstairs, and I stood there, watching her go, my thoughts in overdrive.

That mocha-skinned beauty with jet-black hair I’d seen outside the restaurant. Charlotte. An OnlyFans model. Ethan’s new girlfriend. Was that

why her face tugged at the edges of my memory? Had I seen her online while browsing the web?

The sound of the bedroom door clicking shut upstairs broke me out of my thoughts. I was exhausted from the whirlwind of emotions tonight, but my curiosity wouldn't let me rest. Maybe it was the lingering adrenaline from the video, the shock of seeing Emmie at the restaurant with Mitch, Ethan, and Nate, or the sheer strangeness of her casually mentioning Charlotte's career. Whatever it was, I needed answers.

I grabbed my laptop and settled onto the sofa in the front room, flipping it open. The soft glow of the screen illuminated the dark room as I typed her name into the search bar: *Charlotte Andino*.

The results populated instantly. A quick scroll revealed her Instagram, Twitter, and — my breath hitched slightly — her OnlyFans link. I hesitated for a moment before clicking on the Twitter profile first. It was public, her timeline filled with glossy, professional-looking photos of her in various lingerie sets and bikinis. She was strikingly beautiful, her dusky skin smooth and radiant, her long black hair cascading over her shoulders in waves. The comments beneath each post were flooded with compliments, fire emojis, and occasional lewd remarks.

I scrolled further, trying to keep my focus, but my gaze kept drifting back to her face. Was this where I'd seen her before? It was maddening. I switched tabs and opened her *OnlyFans* page, which previewed a few images but blurred most of the explicit content behind a subscription paywall. A small part of me wondered if I should pay, but that was ridiculous. Wasn't it?

Check out my most intimate content, the banner teased, solo, B/G, and G/G videos with my friend, the one and only Tash xx.

I leaned back on the sofa, exhaling sharply as I returned to the search results. My fingers hovered over the keys before typing, *Charlotte Andino modelling*. Most of the links were social media accounts or older modelling portfolios. I scrolled down, skimming thumbnails until one headline caught my eye: *Former Model Turned OnlyFans Star Once Known as Charlene Andoni*.

Charlene Andoni.

Could it be the same woman? I clicked the article, skimming through the details. It was a fluff piece, really — praising her for taking control of her brand, her image, and turning to platforms like OnlyFans to maintain her

lavish lifestyle. But buried in the middle was a brief mention of her past: “Charlene made a few adult videos early in her career under her real name before changing it to her modelling pseudonym, Charlotte. These rare clips have become a sought-after collector’s item among her devoted fans.”

It *was* her. She’d done adult films? I knew what to do.

Opening a new tab, I navigated to my favourite porn site then hesitated for a moment, glancing toward the stairs to make sure Emmie was still upstairs. The last thing I needed was for her to come down and catch me doing this. Satisfied I was alone, I typed *Charlene Andoni* into the search bar.

Several videos and galleries appeared instantly. There she was, front and centre, her mocha skin and jet-black hair unmistakable. My pulse quickened as I clicked the first video, turning the volume down low. The clip opened with her sitting on the edge of a bed, wearing nothing but a lace thong and a coy smile, looking slightly younger but still stunning. A young man with an Adonis body entered the scene, shirtless and wearing a pair of well-fitted jeans. I skipped forward to the good part, uninterested in the build-up.

My breath caught. Charlene was on her back on the bed, fully naked. Her dark skin glistened like satin, covered in a thin sheen of sweat as she gasped and moaned. The muscular man pounded her, holding her taut thighs against his chest. With each hard thrust, her large, fake breasts bounced. “Oh fuck, oh fuck, ohhhh yes... fuck!”

She was rubbing her pussy hard as he rammed his pornstar-sized cock into her. She knew how to perform for the camera. “God, I love your dick,” she moaned. “I love your big, fucking dick!” She pulled her ringers away from her pussy to tweak her long, dark nipples. Her pussy, I saw, looked perfectly waxed, stretched around the man’s thick shaft.

Fuck, she was good-looking Ethan was fucking this girl? Had a history of dating girls like this? Wow. It must be nice to be so rich.

The scene ended with the guy shooting his load all over her impressive tits. I let my breath return to normal before going back to the thumbnails, scrolling down to find another video, with a different guy. I’d seen this one before. That’s how I knew her face. This video was a good one. I’d watched it more than once.

But then the familiarity hit me like a ton of bricks. It wasn’t just her appearance that was familiar — it was her energy, the way she moved, the way she looked at the camera.

And then it clicked.

My breath caught in my throat as the realization washed over me. Her vibe, her familiarity — it was the same as Natasha's.

Tash.

The OnlyFans description slammed into me like a freight train. Could it really be her? My fingers shook as I typed *Charlene Andoni and Tash* into the porn search bar. The results were almost immediate. And at the top, there it was — a video of the two of them together, their bodies intertwined, in bed with one another. They were staring into one another's eyes, on the verge of a kiss.

My mouth went dry as I clicked the video, watching as Natasha — Luke's Natasha — came into view. Her tall, slim form, her perfectly straight, long, dark hair, those vivid green eyes. It was undeniable. It was her. I clicked the play button.

Tash — Natasha — knocked on the door to the bedroom where Charlene — Charlotte — was “sleeping.” They exchanged a few lines of dialogue that I scrubbed past quickly, and then it was on. Natasha crawled over to Charlene and started to make out. The kissing felt real, or at least not entirely just for show. This certainly wasn't either of their first times around another woman.

I watched, unable to stop, as Luke's girlfriend and her hot, black friend stripped each other. She leaned back into the pillows, spreading her thighs for the other girl to go down on her.

“Oh... fuck, yes...” Tash played it up for the camera as the camera tracked down Natasha's tight, naked body. This felt so wrong, yet I knew there was no way I was going to stop. Not as I watched Charlene's long tongue lap along Natasha's completely shaved little slit. Charlene lifted up, spitting a dollop of saliva onto her smooth pussy before returning her tongue there.

“You like that, don't you, you little slut,” Charlene taunted between licks.

“Yes... yes!”

I shouldn't watch any further. I forced myself to scroll down, Natasha's moans quietly pouring out of the speakers. Below, there were more of her suggested videos filled with lurid promise. I chose the first in the list. Charlene wasn't in this one. Natasha was with a guy — the same one as the first video I'd watched before with Charlene — the young fit dude with the huge dick. Perhaps he was a mutual friend.

I sat there, frozen, my mind racing as I watched him undress her — she was a student in this setup, with a short tartan skirt and her hair in long, twin ponytails. He left her skirt on as he pushed her to her knees. She pulled out his long, thick cock, wrapping her lips around it hungrily, as he grabbed her by the braids.

Luke was planning to propose to this woman. He was head over heels in love with her, talking about forever, about building a life together. Did he know she was a pornstar? Surely he knew. He must do. But did he? He'd have mentioned it when he showed me the nude photos of her on his phone, wouldn't he? Maybe he did know but was embarrassed.

I skipped forward. On the laptop screen, Natasha was fucking the guy now. Her smallish tits were perfectly shaped, her nipples light pink and small. Her pussy looked so fucking good like that, totally shaved again as she rode him, her head thrown back in ecstasy. My cock stiffened in my shorts, recalling the odd encounter with her earlier. What did all of this mean? How did this all add up? My head was spinning.

I scrolled down and saw a few more videos of her, seemingly with different guys. There weren't a whole lot of videos, but she'd certainly explored the world of a pornstar to some degree. She wasn't a one-and-done porn actress.

I scrolled back up. The guy on the screen was behind her now, pounding her relentlessly until she orgasmed for the camera. My chest tightened. I couldn't unsee it. I couldn't un-know it. Luke had no idea who he was about to marry, did he? He wouldn't fall in love with a girl that had a history in porn. Not Luke.

The porn star onscreen pulled out his cock and Natasha knelt in front of him, opening her mouth and extending her tongue. There was no doubt. This was her, her beauty right there in high definition. Her green eyes sparkled as she waited for the guy to pump his load all over her face. She didn't flinch as the thick ropes of cum shot out, some landing on her tongue, some covering her pretty lips, cheeks and chin.

I sat back, my hands gripping the edges of the laptop. Should I tell him? Could I? What would it do to him if I did?

Before I could overthink it, I grabbed my phone. My thumb hovered over Luke's name in my contacts. I needed to tell him. He had to know the truth before he made the mistake of proposing to her this weekend.

But as I pressed my thumb to call, the door creaked open. My heart lurched, and I snapped the laptop shut reflexively, looking up to see Emmie standing there in the doorway.

“Hey,” she said softly, her hair damp from the shower, clinging to her shoulders. She was wearing a thin robe, tied loosely at her waist, her skin glistening slightly with moisture. She looked incredible, her curves accentuated by the light fabric, her stiff nipples poking through sexily, but the sight of her only added to my guilt.

“You okay?” she asked, her brow furrowing slightly.

I forced a smile, hoping it didn’t look as shaky as it felt. “I’m fine,” I said, my voice more even than I expected. “Just... clearing my head. Long day.”

Her eyes flicked to the closed laptop on my lap, lingering for a moment before she walked back into the kitchen. I could see her from where I was sitting. “I came down for a snack and wondered where you’d gone. Thought maybe you’d fallen asleep down here,” she said over her shoulder, her tone casual. “Do you want anything?”

“No, I’m good,” I replied quickly, putting the laptop on the floor, out of her view, just in case she asked to see what I’d been watching.

She opened the fridge, leaning down slightly to grab something. The robe shifted as she moved, revealing a flash of her thigh. She straightened, turning back to me with an apple in her hand. “Alright,” she said, her smile softening. “Don’t stay up too late, okay? I know it’s the weekend but you look tired.”

“I’ll be up in a minute,” I promised, forcing a grin.

She lingered for a moment, her eyes searching mine as if she could sense the turmoil I was trying to keep hidden. But then she nodded, turning and heading back toward the stairs. “Don’t keep me waiting too long,” she said teasingly, her voice carrying a playful lilt.

The sound of her footsteps faded as she went back upstairs, and when I heard the bedroom door click shut again, I let out a breath I didn’t realize I’d been holding, the tension in my chest loosening slightly.

There was no way I could call Luke tonight. It was too late, and Emmie was still awake. Besides, I needed time to process everything, to figure out how I was going to approach this conversation with him.

I put the laptop in a safe place, hiding it in a drawer by the bookshelf and rubbed my hands over my face. My head felt fuzzy, my thoughts a tangled

mess. Natasha, Luke, the video of Emmie, what I'd done with Laura...
How on Earth did my life get to this point?

CHAPTER THREE

Saturday mornings were supposed to be relaxing, but this one had me on edge. I sat at the dining table, nursing a cup of coffee, staring blankly at the steam curling upward. Emmie sat across from me, her face serene as she scrolled through her phone, occasionally taking small bites of her toast. She looked... normal... as if everything was fine.

I guess, in her world, it was.

But not in mine.

I hadn't slept much the night before, the whirlwind of emotions from the day tearing through my mind. We didn't have sex last night, I hadn't even tried. After the shower — where I scrubbed myself raw, trying to wash off the guilt from Laura — I'd come out to find Emmie already asleep, her breathing soft and even. I didn't wake her, I didn't want to face her. If I'm honest, it was a relief.

This morning, though, sitting across from her, guilt pressed down on me like a weight. She deserved better than what I'd done. I knew that. But then again... so did I. Emmie was keeping things from me. Things she didn't want me to know. That she'd not only slept with 'Shaun,' whoever he was but had also entertained at least three guys at our house too, sleeping with two of them and — at the minimum — sucking the other. Those three guys were likely Ethan, Mitch and Nate, something I was hoping to confirm later. And finally, that she'd had a threesome with someone, or at least been filmed having sex by a third party.

I watched her for a moment, the sunlight catching the soft waves of her golden hair, the way it framed her face. She was beautiful, as always, but now I found myself questioning everything. Was she thinking about her secrets even now? Or was she simply enjoying her breakfast, blissfully unaware of the storm brewing in my mind?

I clenched my coffee mug, fighting the urge to confront her. Not yet. If I pushed her now, I'd never see the rest of the videos. I felt ashamed to admit it, but I wanted to see them. No, I needed to see them. While Emmie was in the shower this morning, I'd gotten the laptop and watched the video of her being fucked by the mystery man again. I couldn't resist. But why? Why was I so fixated on this? Was it jealousy? Obsession? Or was I just searching for something to make sense of it all?

She glanced up at me suddenly, her hazel eyes warm. "You okay, babe? You've been quiet all morning."

"Yeah," I said quickly, forcing a small smile. "Just tired, I guess. Long week."

She nodded, accepting my answer without question, and went back to her phone. I swallowed hard, taking another sip of coffee, trying to steady my nerves.

I needed a distraction—something to shift the focus.

"By the way," I started, keeping my tone light, "I looked up your old boss's girlfriend last night, as you suggested. Charlotte Andino, or should I say Charlene?"

Her head shot up, curiosity flickering in her gaze. "Oh? And? What do you mean, Charlene?"

"She doesn't just do OnlyFans," I said, leaning back in my chair. "Apparently, she used to make porn under that name. Not just nude modelling but... you know. Proper porn. Full sex. With men... and women."

If Emmie was surprised, she didn't show it. Instead, she let out a small laugh, shaking her head. "That figures. Ethan's always had a thing for women like that: models, pornstars, wannabe celebs, social media personalities. The flashier, the better. Honestly, I'm not even surprised. Did you know he's married?"

"What?" I frowned.

"Yeah," she said, taking another bite of her toast. "His wife doesn't care, though. She lets him have mistresses as long as she gets to enjoy his money."

Charlotte is just the latest in a long line of them. Some kind of open arrangement, I guess. It's so... Ethan."

I blinked, trying to wrap my head around it. "And she's okay with that?"

Emmie shrugged. "Seems like it. Ethan's a smooth talker. He always finds a way to get what he wants. I mean, look at Charlotte. She's gorgeous, and apparently, she's happy being his latest toy."

"Wow." I shook my head. "He sounds like a total jerk. What do all these women see in him?"

I said that without realising the irony. If my suspicions were correct, Emmie herself had been taken in by his charms last year.

"Money," my wife shrugged, her breasts shifting pleasantly beneath the thin fabric of the white T-shirt she wore. "Although he is charming, in his own way. He has something about him. Power. Influence. I don't know what it is. But he's got it."

"You sound almost like he could charm you." I couldn't help but probe gently, then decided to push harder. "I'm surprised he didn't make a move on you. While we were apart, I mean."

"I'm not a pornstar," Emmie replied quickly. A little too quickly. "I'm not his type. And besides, he's too old for me."

"Right," I nodded, unconvinced, taking a sip of my coffee but keeping my eyes on her, over the rim.

"Anyway," she bit off another chunk of toast as she changed the subject. "I hope you didn't get too excited watching Charlotte last night. I'm guessing if she does porn, you've seen everything?"

"Everything. And... I found something else," I said slowly, observing her reaction. "Something that caught me off guard."

"Oh?" she said, tilting her head slightly.

After watching the video of Emmie this morning, I'd gone back to watching a video of Charlotte's, of her and a black guy, a short but rough sex scene. Then I'd watched one of Natasha, Luke's pretty girlfriend, having sex with an old guy in the back of a car, a simulation of her paying for a taxi fare with her body. I realised I'd seen it before. That was why she seemed familiar. Like most guys, I watched porn sometimes and at some point, I'd seen that video — and no doubt, one of Charlotte's too — hence that similar feeling of knowing her from somewhere.

I took a deep breath, the words feeling heavy in my mouth. "While checking out Charlotte, I saw mention of a... friend. Someone known as

Tash. They've made... content together."

"Okay," Emmie's hazel eyes drifted from her toast to me and then back. "And?"

"Tash," I repeated the name, seeing if she'd catch on, but she didn't. "Tash. Short for Natasha. It's Luke's girlfriend."

Her eyes widened slightly, the toast frozen halfway to her mouth. "What?"

"She's done porn too," I said, my voice low. "There are videos of her online. Not OnlyFans stuff. Like Charlotte... real porn, with men."

Emmie set her toast down, her brow furrowing as she processed what I'd just said. "Are you sure it's her?"

"Positive," I said. "There's even watched a video of them together. Charlotte and Natasha. Girl-on-girl sex."

She let out a low whistle, her expression a mix of shock and something I couldn't quite place. "Charlotte knows Natasha? That's... a weird coincidence. Fuck. Does Luke know?"

"I don't think so," I said. "I don't think he has a clue. I'm sure he'd have mentioned something like that. Plus... he's going to ask her to marry him this weekend. He's taken her to London. That's what he wanted to tell me last night. He showed me the ring and everything."

"He's going to propose? He's only known her for a short time." Emmie leaned back in her chair, crossing her arms over her chest. "I mean... I know he's into her but still... What are you going to do?"

I shook my head, the question hanging heavily in the air. What was I going to do? I opened my mouth to respond, unsure of what to say to Emmie's question, but the sound of the doorbell cut through my thoughts. My brow furrowed as I glanced toward the hallway. We weren't expecting anyone.

"I'll get it," Emmie said, standing up and brushing crumbs from her T-shirt. She disappeared toward the front door, leaving me sitting there, my thoughts racing.

Voices drifted into the dining room, and a moment later, Emmie returned with Jen in tow. My sister-in-law looked as effortlessly polished as always, dressed in a plain cream sweater and jeans that somehow managed to look chic. Her blonde hair was straightened, glossy and perfect, and her makeup was subtle but flawless. But her expression... something about it seemed strained, her usual warmth tempered by an edge of unease.

“Morning, Ryan,” she said brightly, her tone betraying none of the tension I thought I saw in her eyes.

“Hey, Jen,” I replied, forcing a smile. “What brings you here?”

Emmie answered for her. “Oh, I forgot to tell you — Jen needs me to go with her to a meeting. She’s thinking of selling the salon.”

“Selling the salon?” I repeated, my surprise evident. “Since when?”

Jen gave a small shrug, glancing away for a moment. “It’s something I’ve been mulling over for a while now. Business hasn’t been great, and I think I’m ready for a change. Maybe something completely different.” She paused, then added with a faint smile, “Don’t worry, I’ll still cut your hair. Maybe I’ll do mobile hairdressing on the side.”

“I thought you loved the salon,” I questioned but she ignored me, turning to her sister with an excited grin on her face.

“I’m back to seeing Pete again, by the way.”

That was news to Emmie. My wife’s eyes lit up. “Pete? Since when?”

Jen chuckled, her smile turning wry. “Since a couple of weeks ago. He’s been... persistent, let’s say.”

“The on-and-off guy?” I quizzed. “The one you were seeing while Emmie and I were apart?”

“That’s the one,” Jen nodded, licking her lips as if she was suddenly nervous.

I’d seen Pete once or twice. He was a regular at the Red Lion. A friend of Max’s. But before I could press further, Emmie interjected.

“Anyway, Jen wants me to come with her to the meeting. Moral support, I guess.”

“Not just moral support,” Jen clarified. “You’re good at this stuff. I trust your judgment.”

Emmie rolled her eyes playfully but didn’t argue.

Something about the whole situation felt off. The Jen I knew wasn’t the type to give up on her salon. She loved that place. She’d built the business from the ground up. And Pete? Max’s friend? I thought that relationship was dead ages ago. But before I could ask any more questions, Emmie excused herself to grab her coat and shoes.

Jen turned to me as soon as Emmie was out of earshot, her tone shifting. “Ryan, I’m sorry to whisk Emmie away. We’ll only be an hour or so but... I do need to talk to you about something.”

I frowned. “What is it?”

“Nothing to worry about,” she said quickly, holding up a hand. “It’s just... something I need to tell you. But not now. I’ll text you later, okay? We’ll find a time to talk. Just you and me. Away from Emmie.”

Her words sent a ripple of unease through me, but I nodded. “Alright. I’ll make some time... but it sounds ominous.”

Jen gave me a small, reassuring smile, but the tension in her eyes didn’t fade. “Thanks. And don’t worry. It’s not... ominous. I promise.”

Emmie returned a moment later, coat in hand and her hair tied back in a loose ponytail. “I’m ready,” she announced, flashing me a quick smile. “We shouldn’t be long.”

“Take your time,” I said, watching as the two of them headed for the door.

Jen glanced back at me just before stepping outside, her expression unreadable, then silently mouthed, “I’ll text you later.”

I nodded and they left, the door clicking shut behind them, leaving me alone in the quiet house. My mind churned with questions. What did Jen want to talk to me about? Why couldn’t it be with Emmie around? Was it about Pete? The salon? Or was it more? Did she know about the videos somehow? That I was looking into Emmie’s past? She’d seemed agitated last night when she video-called me.

I sat back down, lifting my mug to finish my coffee only to realise it was all gone. My mind was distracted. One thing was becoming increasingly clear: whatever secrets Emmie was keeping, Jen had some of her own. And for some reason, I had a feeling they were connected.

I looked out of the window, watching Jen’s car pull away from our drive, Emmie in the passenger seat. An hour, they’d said. That was plenty of time for me to execute my plan. The idea had come to me this morning after I’d finished watching the videos. Grabbing my phone, I stepped out into the crisp morning air and walked next door, to Laura’s house.

Her back garden was pristine, as always, the lawn neatly trimmed and the flower beds perfectly arranged. I hesitated for a moment before knocking. Footsteps sounded, and a moment later, the door opened.

Laura stood there, her lips curling into a slow smile when she saw me. She was dressed in a thin, silky black robe that barely reached mid-thigh, her legs bare, her curves on full display. Her flame-red hair was tousled like she’d just rolled out of bed — or had a long night.

“Well, well,” she said, leaning against the doorframe, her voice low and teasing. “Didn’t expect to see you again so soon, Ryan. Did you see Mark head out? Couldn’t stay away?”

I cleared my throat, doing my best to keep my eyes on her face. “I need your help with something.”

She arched a perfectly drawn eyebrow, her smile widening. “Oh? And here I thought you were eager for round two.”

Ignoring her blatant flirtation, I held up my phone. “It’s about Emmie. I need you to confirm something for me.”

Laura’s expression shifted slightly, a flicker of curiosity crossing her face. She stepped aside, gesturing for me to come in. “Alright. Come in, then.”

I stepped inside, the familiar scent of her floral perfume wrapping around me. She closed the door behind me and led me to the living room, where she perched on the arm of the sofa, her robe parting slightly to reveal more of her thigh. She didn’t seem to care. I’d seen it all last night.

“So,” she said, folding her arms. “What’s this about?”

I pulled up Facebook on my phone, clicked through to Emmie’s friend list and brought up Ethan’s profile before handing it to her. “Does this look like the grey-haired guy you saw with Emmie?”

Laura took the phone, her brow furrowing slightly as she studied the photo. After a moment, she nodded. “That’s him. No doubt about it. He’s pretty distinctive looking.”

I swallowed hard. My stomach lurched at her words. It was Ethan. She’d been with him. She lied. I took a deep breath, taking the phone back and pulling up Mitch’s profile. He wasn’t on Facebook but he was present on LinkedIn. “And this guy?”

Her lips quirked into a smirk. “The one she sucked off? Yeah, that’s him. I remember that intense look of his, remember thinking he looked like trouble.”

My chest tightened, anger surging through my veins. When this idea had come to me this morning, I’d hoped that Laura wouldn’t be able to help, that none of these faces would be familiar to her. At least with Mitch, I wanted her to say ‘no’ when I showed him to her.

Mitch. You bastard. I should have known. You never liked me. The moment Emmie and I had broken up, even temporarily, you moved in on my territory, on my wife, to get one over on me.

Finally, I pulled up Nate's profile on Facebook, another from Emmie's friend list, handing the phone to her one last time. "And this one? The blond guy?"

Laura glanced at the screen, then shook her head. "Nope. That's not him."

My stomach dropped. After the first two were confirmed, I was sure that Nate would be the third. "Are you sure?"

"Positive," she said, handing the phone back. "I've never seen this guy before. The blond one I saw with Emmie was... bigger. Broader. And his face was different. Sharper, I guess. Less soft."

I stared at the photo, trying to make sense of it. If it wasn't Nate, then who the hell was it?

"At least you know who two of the men are," Laura said softly, her tone almost sympathetic. "As for the third, I don't know. He seemed familiar like he was local. I could go through her Facebook list if you like. See if I recognise anyone else?"

"Thanks," I said, slipping my phone into my pocket. "You have my number. Call me or text if you figure out who it is."

Laura leaned forward slightly, her eyes searching mine. "Ryan... you know you're not going to like where this road takes you, right? You need to stop chasing for answers like this. Talk to her. Don't tell her that I told you anything — I don't want to get dragged into it — but you need to talk to her."

Her words hung heavy in the air, but I didn't respond. I couldn't. Laura was already involved in it. We'd had sex, me and her. Last night, while her husband watched. This was all so fucked up.

I turned toward the door, the weight of everything pressing down on me. I was closer to the truth but I still didn't know everything. However, knowing that Ethan and Mitch were two of Emmie's former lovers gave me somewhere to start. Was the emailer one of those two men? Was one of them the man in the video? Or even the cameraman?

"You don't have to go," Laura murmured, her hand soft on my shoulder. "You can stay for a while. Have a drink. Talk. We don't have to do anything sexual if you don't want to. I can just be a friend. Someone to confide in. And don't worry, your secret — what we did last night — is safe with me. Always."

I turned, my gaze meeting her large brown eyes.

“I appreciate that.” I smiled. “Last night was fun, I can’t deny I enjoyed it, but it shouldn’t have happened. It can’t happen again, Laura. I have to fix my marriage.”

She nodded, giving me an understanding smile. “I hope you’ll still come to our barbecue next weekend. The weather forecast looks perfect.”

“I’ll think about it.” I nodded, then left, striding across the garden back to our house. I had a lot to think about before Emmie came home.

CHAPTER FOUR

I sat at the dining table at home, staring blankly at my phone. A coffee I'd made had long since gone cold while I sat thinking about Ethan, Mitch and the third man, still unidentified. Laura's confirmation had been like a punch to the gut, even though part of me had already expected the answers before she'd spoken. The way she described them—the grey-haired man, the intense one—it all fitted too perfectly.

Ethan. Had he taken advantage of Emmie? Was that why she'd quit her job there and gone to work for Nate? Then there was Mitch. My hands curled into fists at the thought of him. Had he always been there, hovering around Emmie like a vulture, waiting for the slightest crack in our relationship? And then there was the third man. If it wasn't Nate, who the hell was it?

Then there was what I'd learned about Natasha. Pulling out my phone, I stared at Luke's name in my contacts. He deserved to know the truth. My thumb hovered over the call button before I finally pressed it, holding the phone to my ear as it rang.

One ring. Two. Three. Voicemail.

"Luke," I said after the beep. "It's Ryan. Call me back when you can, yeah? It's... important."

The sound of the front door opening jolted me from my thoughts as I hung up. I looked up to see Emmie stepping inside, her cheeks pink from

the cold, Jen right behind her, her hair still perfectly styled despite the chilly weather.

“Hey,” Emmie said, her voice cheerful but with a trace of something I couldn’t quite place. “We’re back. Hope you didn’t miss me too much.”

I forced a smile, standing as they walked in. “Not at all. Everything go okay?”

Jen shrugged as she closed the door behind her, shutting out the cold draught that filled the air. “Fine. Emmie’s been a huge help.”

Emmie gave me a tight smile, though her eyes darted toward Jen, then back to me. “Hey, Ryan. No time to chat, I’m afraid. We’re heading straight out for a drink.”

“Right now?” I asked, frowning slightly.

“Right now,” Emmie confirmed. “Jen deserves one, and so do you. Come on, Ry. It’s Saturday. Let’s relax for a bit.”

Jen nodded, her expression softening. “Come on, Ryan. Just an hour or two. You’ve been cooped up all day.”

I hesitated, the weight of everything pressing down on me. But what was the alternative? Sitting here alone, stewing in my thoughts?

“Alright,” I said finally. “Let’s go.”

We made light conversation on the way to the Red Lion but Jen still wasn’t forthcoming about the reasons for wanting rid of the salon. Emmie asked if I’d managed to talk to Luke about Natasha, but I told her he wasn’t picking up. Then the familiar warmth of the pub washed over me as we stepped inside, the hum of chatter and clinking glasses filling the air.

At the bar, I spotted Max leaning against the counter, chatting animatedly with someone I didn’t recognise. His broad shoulders and easy grin made him hard to miss. He caught sight of us and waved us over, raising his pint in greeting.

“Hey, you three!” Max called, his voice carrying over the din.

“Hey, Max,” Jen said, her tone cheerful but distracted.

We joined Max at the bar, ordering drinks and settling into the rhythm of the pub’s lively atmosphere. A few minutes later, Max’s friend, Pete arrived, his sandy blond hair slightly tousled as though he’d just stepped out of the gym. He had the kind of lean, athletic build that made it clear he took his fitness seriously, his shirt hugging his chest and arms in a way that drew attention. His easygoing grin lit up his face as he slid an arm around Jen’s waist, pulling her close and planting a kiss on her cheek.

“Well, aren’t you a sight for sore eyes,” he said, his voice warm and teasing.

Jen laughed, her cheeks flushing slightly as she leaned into him. “You’re late.”

“Fashionably,” Pete replied, stealing a quick sip from her drink before she could protest.

I’d always had reservations about Pete, he’d messed Jen around in the past but the chemistry between them was palpable, their banter easy and natural. Pete’s arm stayed comfortably around Jen’s waist, his fingers brushing lightly against her side as they exchanged playful jabs. It was impossible not to notice how Jen’s usual sharp edges softened in his presence, her guard dropping in a way that felt rare and unguarded. I just hoped he didn’t fuck her over again like he’d done before.

Emmie caught my eye, a small smile playing on her lips as she watched the pair. “They’re cute together, aren’t they?” she murmured.

I nodded, unable to deny it then took a long sip of my beer, letting the cold liquid steady me, but my thoughts were anything but steady. Pete was blond and well-built. He couldn’t be the third guy that Laura saw, could he? Was that why things were so weird between Emmie and Jen?

Emmie sat across from me, laughing softly at something Max had said, her face glowing with warmth. She looked carefree, untouched by the weight of her past that pressed so heavily on me.

Max raised his pint and leaned back in his seat, his grin easy but his eyes lingering on Emmie for just a moment longer than seemed normal. She gazed back at him and I saw the same look on her face too. It wasn’t obvious—at least, I didn’t think it was—but something about the way they looked at each other sent an odd twinge through me. Then Max and Pete exchanged a glance, one of those wordless exchanges that only close mates could pull off, and Pete smirked slightly before turning his attention back to Jen.

“You alright there, Max?” I asked, my tone casual, though my curiosity was piqued. Was I simply being paranoid? I couldn’t live a life where I was constantly suspecting every guy I met of being one of Emmie’s former lovers.

“Yeah,” he replied easily, but there was a flicker of something in his expression—something I couldn’t quite place. “It’s just good for us to all be together like this, right?”

Emmie laughed softly at something Jen said quietly in her ear, her focus entirely elsewhere, but my mind snagged on that brief moment, the look they'd shared. Max had always been friendly, even protective, of Emmie, but now I wondered if there was more to it.

I shook the thought away, instead turning my attention to the meeting she'd had last night. That was more relevant. I knew for definite that she'd slept with two of the men there. I didn't mention Ethan or Mitch to Emmie yet because I didn't want her to know that I'd traced her to The Dolphin, or that I'd pieced together some of her past with Laura. But the fact that she'd been in a room with two men she'd been intimate with while we were apart made me wonder. What was it like for her last night, being so close to them, in a meeting like that? Did she think about the sex they had? Or had she neatly compartmentalised it, filing it away as ancient history?

I needed to talk to her about it but just as I was about to press her for more details, my phone buzzed on the table, cutting through my thoughts. Luke.

Emmie glanced at the screen and then back at me. "Go ahead. Answer it," she said, her tone casual, though her eyes lingered on me for a moment too long. Had she sensed that my mind was miles away, on other things?

I hesitated, then stood up, gesturing toward the bar. "I'll just take this over here." I pressed the answer button as I stepped away from the table. "Luke," I said, forcing a lightness into my tone. "How's London treating you?"

"Ryan!" Luke's voice was full of excitement, practically buzzing through the phone. "It's been bloody amazing. I was just about to call you. Guess what?"

"What?" I asked, though his tone gave me a pretty big clue.

"She said yes!" he said, nearly shouting down the line at me. "Natasha said yes!"

I blinked, caught off guard by the elation in his voice. "You proposed already?" My heart sank. I was too late. "That's fantastic! Congratulations. How'd you do it?"

"On top of The Shard," he said, the pride in his voice unmistakable. "We had dinner at the restaurant, and then when the time felt right, I got down on one knee. She cried, Ryan. Proper tears. She said she never thought someone like me would want to marry her. Can you believe that?"

I couldn't help but smile, his happiness was contagious even though I felt a sense of dread at what I had to tell him. "That's fantastic, Luke. Really. I'm happy for you both."

"Thanks, mate," he said, his voice softening slightly. "I feel like the luckiest bloke alive right now."

I hesitated, the words I needed to say almost sticking on my tongue. I didn't want to ruin his moment, but he deserved to know. "Luke... there's something I need to talk to you about. It's not easy, but I wouldn't bring it up unless I thought it was important."

The excitement in his voice dimmed just a fraction. "What is it?"

"It's about Natasha," I said carefully. "I don't know how to say this but..."

There was a pause, and when he spoke again, his voice was steady but guarded. "Go on."

"Last night, Emmie went out with some guys from work," I began, choosing my words cautiously. "And she met a woman called Charlotte."

"Okay," my friend replied. "So...?"

I continued, telling him that Emmie had learned she was an OnlyFans model and when I looked her up, I found more content of hers, including full hardcore porn.

"There was a video of hers with a guest, a friend. A woman called Tash," I slowed down, fearing the worst as I got to the critical part. "Luke, it was Natasha. *Your* Natasha."

Luke sighed, and for a moment, I thought he might hang up. But then he said, "I know."

"You know?" I asked, the surprise evident in my voice.

"Yeah," he said. "She told me about it early on. She did porn. It's in her past, Ryan. She was with someone—an ex-boyfriend, who talked her into it. She did a few videos, made some pay-to-view stuff for OnlyFans, then realised it wasn't for her, and got out. It's not who she is now."

An ex-boyfriend? Could it be Ethan? Surely not.

"And you're okay with it?" I asked.

"I'm more than okay with it," Luke said firmly. "It doesn't define her, and it doesn't change how I feel about her. I'm marrying Natasha, not her past."

I leaned against the bar, his conviction sinking in. I could tell he was being serious. "I just... I didn't want you to be blindsided."

"I appreciate that," he said, his tone softening. "But you don't need to worry about us, Ryan. We're good. Better than good, actually."

I nodded, though he couldn't see it. "Alright. I'm glad. Really."

"Listen, why do you think I showed you those nudes of hers?" Luke continued. "I wondered if you might have seen her before. It was my way of telling you... without telling you."

That made sense.

"I see," I exhaled, feeling slightly better about it now. "Plus, you were trying to get me to show you Emmie's video."

I was trying to lighten the mood slightly and it worked.

"Well, yeah. That too," Luke chuckled. "I bet you've watched all of Nat's videos, so you definitely need to show me that one of Emmie now."

"Maybe," I joked back, even though I had no intention of showing it to him. "I might as well tell you now... I don't know who the guy was in the video, or who sent it to me but I know she slept with more than one guy while we were apart and I know who a couple of them are. It's not good."

"Ryan," he said, his voice lowering slightly. "Don't let whatever you're digging into mess things up for you and Emmie. Trust me, mate. It's not worth it."

His words struck a chord, but it still felt good to finally tell someone, to talk to someone who wasn't Laura.

"Thanks, Luke," I said quietly.

"Anytime," he replied. "Now relax. Stop worrying about what Emmie did while you weren't together and you don't need to worry about Natasha's past either. You've got the wedding to look forward to. I'm going to need a best man, you know?"

My heart surged with affection for my friend and joy at what he was saying. "If you're asking me to be your best man, I'd be honoured."

"I'll make sure you've got plenty of time to write your speech," he replied, happiness evident in his tone. "Right, I gotta go. I'll see you next week for a drink."

"Definitely," I confirmed. "Congratulations again."

We hung up, and I stared at the phone for a moment before slipping it back into my pocket. Emmie looked up at me, her brow furrowed in mild concern as I returned to the table.

"Everything alright?" she asked.

“Yeah,” I said, forcing a smile. “Luke’s in London. He just proposed to Natasha. And she said yes.”

Her hazel eyes widened in surprise, then softened into a smile. “That’s wonderful. She’s a lucky girl.”

“Yeah,” I said, my voice trailing off as I sat back down. She was lucky to have Luke. He was a great guy. But was Luke lucky to have Natasha? Was she really as perfect a woman as he said, or just good at hiding her secrets, like so many others in my life right now?

CHAPTER FIVE

The pub's atmosphere had settled into a comfortable hum, the earlier buzz mellowing as the afternoon wore on. Jen and Pete were lost in their own world, her hand casually resting on his thigh as they leaned into each other, exchanging quiet words only they could hear. Across from me, Max sipped his pint, his easy grin still in place and then there was me, nursing my drink, half-listening to the conversation but fully consumed by the thoughts spinning in my mind. Luke's news about Natasha and the unease it had stirred lingered like an itch I couldn't quite scratch. And, of course, there was Emmie—always Emmie—laughing, talking, glowing, while I sat there wondering what other secrets she was keeping from me.

Then the door to the pub creaked open, and a familiar voice carried above the hum of conversation. "Well, well, well. Look who it is—my favourite dysfunctional family!"

I turned to see someone I hadn't seen in a while striding into the Red Lion, exuding confidence with every step. Tall and lean, with perfectly coiffed, curly, dark brown hair that always looked like it had been styled by a professional, Oliver was the kind of man who drew attention without trying. Affectionately known to Emmie and Jen as their 'gay best friend,' Oli's emerald-green jumper clung just enough to his slim frame to suggest that he had a toned body hidden away, and his sharp, angular features lit up with a grin that was equal parts charm and mischief. A brown satchel hung over one shoulder, its contents probably an eclectic mix of designer gadgets

and half-used notebooks—Oli was a university student and carried his things with him everywhere, as much a perfectionist as he was a chaos magnet.

“Oliver!” Emmie called, standing to greet him. She threw her arms around him, and he hugged her tightly, lifting her slightly off the ground. Jen followed suit, receiving a mock kiss on both cheeks in true dramatic fashion.

“Ladies,” he said, his voice dripping with theatrical flair. “Max and Peter... And Ryan.” He nodded at me with a smirk as he slid into the seat beside Jen. “I’m back from studying in Germany and can I say what a pleasure it is to grace you all with my presence this fine day?”

“Good to see you too, Oli,” I said, raising my pint in a mock toast.

“Always the charmer,” he teased, his pale blue eyes drifting over Max and Pete before his focus shifted back to the sisters. “Now, tell me everything. What’s new? Who’s in trouble? Who’s getting divorced?” He paused, his eyes glinting as they landed on Emmie. “And most importantly, who’s fucking who these days?”

I tensed slightly at his words, though everyone else laughed. Oliver had been a fixture in Emmie and Jen’s lives for years, practically family. Emmie often told me how they shared everything—everything. If that was true, then Oli knew. He must know about her lovers, about her past, about Shaun, Ethan, Mitch, maybe even the video. Did he know who was in the threesome? Did Emmie spill her secrets to him late at night over a bottle of wine? The thought made my stomach twist. Should I ask him? Could I even risk it? No. Not yet. Oli wasn’t the type to keep things quiet, especially from Emmie. He’d run straight to her, spilling whatever I said.

“Well, I’ve got news,” Oli said, interrupting my spiralling thoughts. “While I was away, I was shortlisted for that London job. The one with the arts council. I can do it while studying for my doctorate.”

Jen and Emmie lit up, their congratulations spilling over each other. Oli basked in it, throwing dramatic thank-yous their way. I stayed quiet, watching the three of them interact fondly, watching Pete and Jen kiss, listening to her tell Oli all about how they’d decided to give their rocky relationship another go. As the afternoon wore on into the evening, her tongue loosened by the several glasses of wine that she’d enjoyed, Emmie told Oliver about Luke’s engagement and how his new bride-to-be was a

pornstar. That was the talk of the table for a while, garnering Max's attention especially.

Eventually, the drinks dwindled, and the group's energy started to wane.

"Alright," Jen said, standing and stretching. "I think that's us. Thanks for the drinks, boys."

Oliver made an exaggerated bow, then leaned in to hug both sisters again. "We'll catch up properly soon," he promised before glancing at me. "Ryan, try to keep this rabble in line, will you?"

"I'll do my best," I replied, forcing a smile.

We all made our way to the door, saying goodbyes and parting ways. Emmie lingered outside with Oli, her arm linked through his as they said their final farewells. I hung back, managing to catch Jen alone for a moment.

"When do you want to have that talk?" I asked, keeping my voice soft but serious.

"I haven't forgotten," she said quietly, her voice low enough not to carry. She glanced at Emmie before continuing. "We'll talk soon but now isn't the time."

I hesitated. "Jen, what's going on?"

She shook her head. "It's not something I can just explain in passing. It's about what Emmie did... while you were apart. I didn't tell you the whole truth."

"I know," I sighed, the weight of her words settling heavily on me. "There wasn't just Shaun. There were other men too."

"How do you know?" Her eyes flashed with something like alarm. Shit. I didn't want to say too much and make her worried to tell me anything. She clearly wanted to tell me.

"I just know," I shrugged. "I know Emmie. I know when she's not telling me everything."

Jen seemed relieved. "Oh, right. That makes sense. We will talk, okay? I promise. As soon as it's possible, I'll text you and we'll meet." She smiled faintly, patting my arm before heading to her taxi, where Pete was waiting for her. Max was still in the pub and Oli had left, so Emmie returned to my side, her cheeks flushed from the chilly air.

"Ready to go?" she asked, slipping her arm through mine.

I nodded, my thoughts still tangled. Whatever Jen had to tell me, it was clear it would change something. And in the back of my mind, Oli's words

echoed faintly.

Who's fucking who?

A short time later, we stumbled through the door together, Emmie giggling as she kicked off her heels and nearly tripped over the edge of the rug. We were both tipsy, too much to drive, so we'd gotten a taxi home too.

"Careful," I murmured, steadying her by the waist. Her warmth pressed against me, and I caught a whiff of her perfume, rich and sweet.

"Thanks, my hero," she teased, her voice low and sultry as she leaned in to kiss my cheek. Her lips lingered for a second longer than usual, her breath hot against my skin. "How'd the talk with Luke go? You looked a little tense earlier."

I shut the door and leaned back against it, my mind spinning not just from the alcohol but from everything that had happened. "It was... good, I think."

"Did you tell him about the porn stuff?" Emmie asked, swaying as she leaned against the bottom of the staircase railing.

I hesitated. "Yeah. He already knows about it. Her ex-boyfriend got her into making the videos. Luke says it doesn't matter to him now. Just like the ex-boyfriend, it's all in her past and not who she is now."

Emmie nodded slowly, chewing her bottom lip. Was she thinking about Ethan too, wondering if he was the ex Luke spoke of? Or was she mulling over what I'd just said and how it was relevant to our own situation?

We stood there for a moment, the silence stretching, thick with unspoken questions. "He's probably right. I mean... people change, don't they? I'm not who I was when we were apart." She paused, her gaze flickering over me, then stepped closer, her fingers lightly trailing over my arm. "Speaking of Natasha's past... you watched her videos, right?"

Her question caught me off guard, and my breath hitched slightly. "I... yeah, I did. I told you."

Her lips curved into a small, mischievous smile. "And? Was she good? Hot?"

I blinked, unsure how to respond, then laughed. "That's a trap question, isn't it? I'm not answering that."

Emmie giggled then shrugged, her gaze flicking toward the stairs. "I was just curious. You know, about what kind of stuff she did. What she looked like." Her voice dropped slightly, her tone turning playful. "Do you still have it? The video?"

“Yeah,” I said cautiously, watching her closely.

She tilted her head, her eyes gleaming with something I couldn’t quite place. “Want to watch it? Together?”

“What?” I frowned, caught off guard. “Are you serious?”

“Why not?” she said, her smile widening. “I’ve had a few drinks, and I’m curious. Plus...” Her fingers trailed up my chest, her touch sending a shiver through me. “I think it might be fun.”

I hesitated, torn between the strangeness of the suggestion and the undeniable heat in her gaze. “Alright,” I finally said, grabbing my phone. “Let’s go upstairs.”

We climbed the stairs together, Emmie’s hand sliding into mine as we entered the bedroom. She kicked the door shut behind her and slipped out of her dress. It hit the ground, leaving a tantalizing view of her in just her lacy black bra and thong. I couldn’t help but stare as she climbed onto the bed, turning and propping herself up against the pillows.

“Come on, get your phone out. Show me,” she purred, patting the space beside her.

I got on the bed, and Emmie sidled up beside me, placing a hand on my chest, one knee over the other, looking on as I pulled up one of the videos. It felt surreal, opening it in front of her, but she seemed completely unbothered, even eager.

I hit play, and the screen filled with the image of Natasha—slim, tanned, and naked—kneeling on a bed, her vivid green eyes glinting at the camera as she slowly undid the tie on a man’s robe.

“She’s gorgeous,” Emmie murmured, her voice low.

That was quite an understatement. Natasha’s hair was drawn back in a high ponytail, and she wore far more makeup than she had when we’d met in real life, yet somehow that juxtaposition added to the eroticism of this act.

She fished out the man’s long, thick cock, jerking it slowly as she stared up at him. Emmie’s fingers tightened on my chest as Natasha leaned forward and took that cock into her mouth. She sucked him expertly, the wet sounds of her mouth echoing in the quiet of the bedroom.

I was so hard, watching this again, thinking about my buddy’s now fiancée and what she’d done in her past. The angle shifted as she moved to straddle him. She positioned his thick cock against her smooth snatch, her toned

body arching as she sank down onto him. His length spread her open wide, disappearing into her shaved pussy.

After growing comfortable with this position, he rolled her onto her back, the camera lingering on her perky breasts as they bounced with each powerful thrust. Her moans filled the room through the phone's speakers.

I risked a glance at Emmie, and my pulse quickened. Her cheeks were flushed, her lips slightly parted, her gaze fixed on the screen. "She's so sexy. If you were single, would you fuck her?"

Her question caught me off guard and for a moment, I couldn't speak. Then she looked over at me, her eyes searching mine. Leaning in, her lips brushing against my ear, she repeated the question. "Would you?"

I swallowed hard, my voice barely a whisper. Emmie fucked several men while she was single. Why should I be tactful?

"Yeah. I guess I would," I dared to breathe, looking her into her eyes. "Would you fuck the guy she's with? He's got a hot body and a big cock."

She smiled, a wicked look on her face as she climbed into my lap, her hips pressing against mine. Then she reached down and touched my cock through my jeans, finding it erect. "If I was single?"

"Yes," I moaned as she rubbed me, tracing the shape of my dick. "Would you?"

Her only answer was to kiss me, hard and demanding, her hands tugging at my shirt as she ground against me. The video continued to play in the background, but my focus was entirely on her—on the heat of her body, the urgency in her movements.

She pulled away just long enough to strip off her bra and panties. Before I knew it, she yanked down my trousers and boxers with fierce determination. "I want you," she whispered, her voice raw. "I want you to cum inside me. Put a baby in me."

Her words sent a jolt of arousal through me, and before I could think, she was lowering herself onto me, her wet pussy enveloping me easily. She was so wet, so ready, and she moved with a desperation I'd never seen before, her nails digging into my shoulders. She rode me with abandon, grinding herself against me, my dick buried deep inside her. My mind flickered back to the video, to Natasha being pounded hard on all fours, and suddenly the idea of Emmie in her place filled my head, my wife being fucked hard like that, by a big, thick cock, like the one on the screen.

“You didn’t just fuck Shaun.” The words came out of my mouth before I could stop them. “Did you? It’s okay. I’m not judging you.”

Emmie’s eyes widened, but she didn’t reply straight away. Her large breasts bounced in front of my face as she slammed her pussy down onto me hard, biting her lip in pleasure. As I stared at her, trying to will a response from her, she slowed, gyrating her hips in a tight circle. Her reply was soft, perhaps slightly nervous but also unmistakably deepened with desire.

“Okay, I guess I should admit it,” she murmured. “There were a couple of others.”

“Did any of them...” I hesitated, looking at Luke’s girlfriend being fucked roughly on the laptop screen set at the side of us. “Did any of them have a big cock? Did they fuck you hard, like that?”

Emmie blinked, an expression I didn’t recognise fleeting across her face for a moment. Was it confusion at why I was asking such a fucked-up question? Reluctance? Guilt?

She looked at the video, watched Natasha being fucked for a moment. “One of them was big,” she confessed. “Like him.”

I stiffened inside of her, grabbing her hips and guiding her harder, up and down along my shaft, which I could feel beginning to throb.

“And... oh, fuck... And yes, I got fucked... hard.”

Was she thinking about it now? I drove into her hard, pushing upwards to meet her as she came down onto me.

“But that was while we were apart,” she said between heavy breaths. “It... doesn’t matter, okay?” She groaned, bouncing on me harder and faster. “I love you, Ry. Now cum for me. I can tell you’re close.”

I didn’t last. Not with her confession, not with the thought of her getting fucked roughly by a big cock. I gripped her hips tightly as I came, filling her wet pussy with my seed. Emmie’s fingers found her clit, rubbing herself sensually as she continued to grind against me, until she too came, her moans loud. I wondered if she’d moaned as loud as this when Laura and Mark had heard her from their back garden, with whoever it was that had fucked her back then.

Afterwards, she curled against me, her head on my chest, her long, blonde waves cascading over me. She sighed contentedly, her breathing slowing as she drifted off to sleep. I lay there, staring at the ceiling, my thoughts a chaotic mess. She was coming closer to divulging her secrets.

The video and whoever was in it, the fact that she'd fucked Ethan and Mitch and the third guy, she might just tell me, if I played it right.

Should I ask her right out for the answers, now that she was slowly opening up? Or did I play the long game and give the emailer a chance to send me the other videos that he mentioned? I wasn't sure, but one thing I did know was this: I loved the woman curled against me and never wanted to lose her.

CHAPTER SIX

Monday morning came too quickly, the dull hum of the office bringing me back to reality. The weekend had felt like a blur. Sunday had been... normal. Unsettlingly so. Emmie and I had fallen into our usual routine—breakfast together, a trip to the supermarket, a lazy afternoon in front of the TV. She'd laughed at some reality show, curled up next to me on the sofa like everything was fine. Like everything was how it used to be.

But it wasn't.

Saturday night had given me a glimpse of something deeper. The way she'd opened up, even if only slightly, during our lovemaking—playfully, almost wistfully admitting her curiosity about Natasha's videos and then admitting that she'd slept with more than just one man—had felt like progress. Encouraging. It had made me think that maybe, just maybe, I could push her further. Get her to tell me everything without the need for the videos or the looming threat of the emailer. But when I tried to bring it up again on Sunday, she'd deflected, turning the conversation back to mundane topics. The weather. Work. Dinner plans.

By the time I'd gone to bed, I felt like I'd made no progress at all. Worse, I was trapped. Stuck between wanting to confront her outright and needing to uncover the truth for myself. The emailer's promise of more videos gnawed at me, the temptation impossible to ignore.

I'd texted Laura, hoping she might have some answers about the third man. If she could identify him, maybe it would give me something to work

with. But her reply had been vague:

Been busy. Will look at it soon.

So here I was, back at my desk, my inbox filling with emails I couldn't bring myself to care about. The usual office background noise of conversation from nearby cubicles blended with the dull clicks of mouse buttons and tappity-tap-taps of keyboards. I was supposed to be catching up on reports, but my mind was anywhere but here.

Worse yet, I had a meeting lined up with Mitchell fucking Davison. I looked at the clock. 11.45 AM. He should have been here fifteen minutes ago but I'd gotten a message that he was running late. That was a small mercy. His absence gave me room to breathe, though it didn't stop my thoughts from distracting me from my work. I'd been trying to piece together what to do next. Luke was still in London, basking in the glow of his engagement. I'd decided to talk to him as soon as he got back. Luke was steady, reliable, and he'd given good advice before. He'd tell me if I was overthinking everything. Or if I was making the biggest mistake of my life by letting this fester.

I took a sip of my coffee, grimacing at the bitterness. I'd made it way too strong, so I walked to the canteen to make myself a fresh cup. The office felt stifling today, the air thick with the weight of my own unease. Sophie breezed past me in the corridor, her perfume lingering in her wake, and I caught a flicker of something in her expression when she glanced my way. Was she still thinking about Friday when she'd casually hit on me? I couldn't tell, and I didn't have the energy to care.

A steaming hot drink in hand, I returned to my desk but just as I was about to sit down, the lift dinged, and I glanced up. Mitch strode from the silver doors into the office, dressed sharply, as always, his tailored suit fitting him like a glove. His confidence radiated through the room, a stark contrast to my fraying nerves.

Our eyes met briefly as he approached, and his lips curved into a smug smile. He didn't say anything, didn't need to. The look was enough. It was the same look he'd given me for months, the same one that now carried the truth of what I knew. Laura's confirmation that he'd been one of Emmie's lovers.

I felt an unexpected surge of anger bubbling beneath the surface as Mitch approached my desk. His smug grin, that air of confidence he carried—it all grated against me like sandpaper. I hadn't expected the current of rage that

now simmered in my chest. Sure, I'd known he was the kind of guy who thrived on making others feel small, but now it was personal. Now, I knew what he'd done.

"Ryan," Mitch greeted, his tone smooth as silk. "Thanks for squeezing me in. I know you're a busy man."

I forced a curt nod, gesturing toward the chair opposite my desk, forcing down my dislike for him. "No problem. Let's get started."

Mitch sat down, crossing one leg over the other, the picture of nonchalant confidence. "Before we dive into the boring stuff, I have to say, it was great running into Emmie the other night."

My heart started to thump in my chest, even more anger swelling up from nowhere. "Oh?"

"Yeah," he said, leaning back in his chair, his eyes glinting with mischief, or something more. "She looked incredible, as always. That dress she was wearing—damn. You're a lucky guy, Ryan. She's something else."

My grip on the edge of my desk tightened. The casual way he spoke about her, the knowing tone in his voice—it made my blood boil. But I swallowed the rage, forcing myself to stay calm.

"Let's focus on the meeting," I said stiffly, opening the file on my desk. "You wanted to discuss—"

"You know," Mitch interrupted, his smirk widening, "Back in school, I always knew you'd end up with Emmie or someone hot like her. Quiet, steady Ryan, landing the girl everyone else wanted. Never could figure out how you did it. A guy like you."

It was bait, plain and simple. And I was falling for it. My chest tightened, my fists clenching under the desk as I struggled to keep my composure.

"Mitch," I said, my voice low, warning. "This isn't the time."

He chuckled, leaning forward slightly. "Relax, mate. I'm just saying. Emmie's a catch. Always has been. Always will be. Seeing her in the meeting with Ethan made me realise that."

The words hit me like a sledgehammer, the subtext clear. My vision blurred slightly, the edges of my self-control fraying as anger surged through me. A mental image rose unbidden in my mind, of Emmie and Mitch in our front room, her on her knees like Laura described, sucking his cock.

"You know," he continued. "Maybe I should—"

“Change the subject, Mitch.” My words came out almost as a growl. I could hear my pulse in my ears. I feel it throbbing in my temple.

“What’s up, Ryan?” He arched an eyebrow, a disarming smile growing across his face. “I’m complimenting your wife. Saying you’re a lucky guy.”

“Did you fuck her?” The words came out before I could stop them, my voice sharp and cutting through the tension that had built up in the air between us. “After she sucked your cock?”

Mitch froze, his smirk faltering for the briefest moment before he recovered. “What are you—”

“How many times?” I asked, leaning forward over the desk towards him. “How many times did you do it? Was she good? Did you cum on her face? Or on her tits? Inside her?”

“Ryan—” Mitch started, holding up a hand.

“Don’t play dumb,” I snapped, standing abruptly. My chair scraped loudly against the floor, drawing a few glances from nearby desks. “You think I don’t know? You think I haven’t figured it out?”

“Slow down.” His eyes were wide with shock. What did he expect, taunting me like that? “Let’s talk about this.”

“Don’t you dare deny it,” I growled, stepping closer. “You fucked my wife while we were on our break. Maybe you’ve fucked her since then. Or you want to, at least. You *and* Ethan. Did you have a threesome?”

Mitch’s face hardened, his voice low and measured. “You’ve got this all wrong.”

“Have I?” I barked, the anger spilling over. “My neighbour saw you with Emmie through the window. She saw you together, in my house, in my front room. She saw everything. So don’t give me that shit. You think you can just walk in here, flash that smug grin, and pretend like nothing happened?”

His jaw clenched and he stood up, taking a half-step towards me. “Just sit the fuck down, Ryan.”

Oh no. You’re not going to intimidate me any more, Mitchell fucking Davison.

The boiling rage inside me erupted. My fist shot forward, connecting with his jaw with a satisfying thud. The impact sent him stumbling back, his chair toppling over as gasps filled the office.

“Ryan, stop!” T.J.’s voice cut through the chaos as he rushed over, grabbing my arm and pulling me back. “What the hell are you doing?”

Mitch straightened slowly, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand. A trickle of blood escaped the corner of his lips, his expression a mixture of shock and anger. "You're making a mistake," he said, his voice low but firm. "This isn't what you think."

But I wasn't listening. I couldn't. The adrenaline coursing through me drowned out everything else. All I could see was his smug face, his knowing smirk, the way he'd talked about Emmie. I wrestled out of T.J.'s grasp and lunged for him again but T.J. managed to grab me again, pulling me back once more.

"Get him out of here," Helen's voice rang out, sharp and authoritative. She stood near the lift, her arms crossed, her expression unreadable.

T.J. tightened his grip on my arm, steering me toward the exit. "Come on, Ryan. Let's go."

Mitch didn't say another word. He rubbed at the streak of red running down his chin, smearing it across his jaw and his eyes burned into mine as I was led away. I could still hear the murmurs of the office behind me, the ripple of shock and gossip spreading through the room.

As T.J. led me toward the canteen, I caught sight of Sophie near her desk, her brown eyes wide, fixed on me. Her usual confidence seemed shaken, her expression caught somewhere between shock and curiosity.

"What did you do?" she called out softly but I didn't answer. She didn't say anything further, but her gaze lingered, following me as T.J. pulled me away.

"Alright, sit down," T.J. said as we entered the canteen, his tone a mix of concern and irritation. He pushed me gently into a chair, grabbing a bottle of water from the nearby fridge and placing it in front of me. "What the hell just happened, man? Mitch might be a dick, but punching him? That's not like you. Fuck. No, this is bad."

I took the bottle, twisting the cap off and taking a long drink. My hand trembled slightly as I set it back down, the adrenaline still coursing through me. "It's complicated."

"No shit," T.J. replied, sitting across from me. "I've known you for a while now, Ryan. You're not a guy who loses it like that. Talk to me. Maybe I can help."

I hesitated, the burden of my secrets pressing down on me. How much could I tell him? How much should I tell him? I'd lost control. Completely. I needed to get it back.

Think straight, Ryan.

The gravity of what I'd done began to sink in. What if Mitch was telling the truth? What if I really *had* gotten this all wrong?

"Ryan?" T.J. put a hand on my shoulder. "Are you okay? What's going on?"

"It's... personal," I said finally, my voice low. "It's about Emmie. Mitch crossed a line. While we were apart. That's all I can say."

T.J.'s eyebrows lifted for a moment, surprise evident on his face. Then he frowned, his concern deepening. "Look, that sounds messy, but you need to think about your job. Mitch is a big deal for the company. Helen's not going to take this lightly."

As if summoned by his words, Helen walked into the canteen, her expression as stern and unreadable as ever. "T.J., give us a minute."

T.J. glanced between us, reluctant to leave, but eventually nodded and stood. "Think about what I said, Ryan," he said before leaving the room.

Helen sat down and folded her hands on the table, her sharp eyes narrowing as she leaned in slightly. Her presence was commanding, yet there was a quiet restraint to her demeanour. Her dark hair was glossy and sleek, pinned back into a bun that accentuated her angular cheekbones. The warm tones of her immaculate skin were complemented by the cream-coloured blouse she wore, paired with a tailored navy blazer. Her makeup was minimal but flawless, her lips painted a soft berry shade that gave her an air of elegance. Even in a moment like this, Helen looked as if she'd stepped out of a power-dressing magazine shoot—poised, calculated, and utterly unshakeable.

"Let's skip the bullshit," she began, her tone sharp but not unkind. "What's going on, Ryan? And don't give me some vague 'it's personal' excuse. You've got a problem, and now it's the company's problem."

I swallowed hard, the lump in my throat making it difficult to speak. "I... I lost my temper."

Her brows arched. "Clearly. But why? Mitch is a smug asshole and I know you have some sort of history, sure, but I've never seen you lash out at anyone."

My hand tightened around the water bottle, the plastic crinkling under the pressure. There was something about Helen—her directness, her no-nonsense attitude—that made it impossible to deflect. Maybe it was the way she looked at me like she could see straight through every excuse I might

conjure up. Or maybe it was the warmth that I just realised was hidden beneath her stern exterior, a quiet empathy that made me feel like I could actually tell her the truth.

“It’s complicated,” I said again, though this time it felt less like a deflection and more like an admission of defeat.

Helen tilted her head slightly, her eyes softening but only just. “Ryan, I’m not asking for your life story. I’m asking for enough context to decide whether or not I’m going to fire you. So start talking.”

I exhaled sharply, rubbing a hand over my face. “It’s about my wife. Emmie. Mitch... slept with her... while we were apart.”

Helen didn’t react immediately. Her gaze remained steady, calculating, as if she were piecing together a puzzle in her mind. “And you found out recently?”

“Just this weekend,” I admitted, my voice low. “I found some condoms that Emmie says were from our break. She wouldn’t tell me who she’d slept with so... I’ve been... piecing things together myself. Trying to figure out what happened. I don’t even know the whole truth yet but I found out that Mitch was one of the guys she went with.”

“And Mitch confirmed this himself?” she asked, her tone carefully neutral.

“Not exactly,” I muttered, my shame bubbling to the surface. “I confronted him. He didn’t deny it, but he didn’t admit it either. I guess I didn’t give him much of a chance.”

Helen leaned back slightly, crossing her arms over her chest. “So you punched him before he could say anything?”

I nodded, unable to meet her gaze. “He started talking about Emmie. He was taunting me. Winding me up.”

A long silence stretched between us, the hum of the office faintly audible in the background. Finally, Helen let out a slow breath, shaking her head. “You’re a good worker, Ryan. Steady. Reliable. I never pegged you as the kind of guy who lets personal shit spill over into the office.”

“I’m not,” I said quickly, desperation creeping into my voice. “I mean, I wasn’t. This isn’t like me, Helen. I just... I lost it.”

She studied me for a moment, her expression softening slightly. “Listen. I get it. Personal stuff has a way of creeping into every corner of your life if you let it. Trust me, I know.”

Her words caught me off guard. “You... do?”

She hesitated for a moment, her gaze flickering away briefly before returning to mine. “I know I’ve been a bit of a bitch in the office recently. That’s because I’ve been going through a divorce. A messy divorce,” she said, her tone quieter now. “My husband cheated on me. It was ugly. It was painful. But you know what I didn’t do? Let it interfere with my work.”

I blinked, surprised by her candour. “I’m sorry,” I said softly. “That must’ve been... awful.”

“It was,” she admitted. “And yeah, I was angry. Still am, sometimes. But anger doesn’t fix anything. It doesn’t change what happened. All it does is eat away at you.”

“Then how do you deal with it?” I asked, genuinely curious. “How do you just... let it go?”

Helen’s expression shifted, a flicker of vulnerability crossing her face. “You don’t, not entirely. You learn to live with it. But mostly, you learn to focus on what’s next. You get your shit together and move forward because standing still only makes the pain worse.”

Her words hit me harder than I expected. “So... you’re not angry anymore?”

She gave a small, humourless laugh. “Anger fades. Now? I’m just lonely.”

The honesty in her voice was stark, almost jarring. I didn’t know what to say, so I simply nodded, the weight of her words settling over me like a heavy blanket.

Helen straightened, her professional composure snapping back into place like a shield. “Take the rest of the week off, Ryan. Paid. Use the time to get your head on straight. If we lose Mitch as a client, you’ll face a disciplinary hearing. Prepare for that possibility.”

“I get it,” I nodded, standing as she did. “I’m sorry.”

“It is what it is.” Helen’s posture softened again and she sat on the corner of the desk, her eyes looking down at the floor for a long moment. “I shouldn’t have given you the Mitch account back in the first place but Sophie was about to fuck it up, so I had no choice.”

“She was about to fuck it up?” I asked.

“I can’t give it back to Sophie because, between you and I, she’s talking about leaving,” Helen sighed. “She wants a change of career. To set herself up in some other business, I don’t know what. I’m trying to talk her out of

it. She's an asset to the company even if she can't keep her legs closed at times."

Hearing Helen talk so openly was strange. I'd put her in a difficult position, I realised. She'd been through a tough time herself and I was piling even more stress on her.

"Still, this is my fault. I'm sorry," I apologised again.

"Don't be sorry, Ryan," she said, her tone softening slightly. She stood and walked around the desk, stopping in front of me. To my surprise, she reached up with a delicate hand and placed it on my cheek, studying me for a moment, her dark eyes burning into mine. Her body was so close, I could almost feel her warmth. Helen had a fuller figure, curvy but in all the right places. She was older than me, mature, but still beautiful. The curves of her breasts rose and fell in the gap of her jacket. I couldn't help but admire her cleavage for a second, then dragged my eyes back to hers. For a moment, there was an odd connection between us. Or was I imagining it?

"Helen..." I started to say, but she put a red-painted fingernail against my lips, silencing me.

"I know," she murmured. She knew what? She smiled softly. "Go home. Talk to your wife. Sort your shit out."

With that, she turned and walked away, her heels clicking against the tile floor. I stood there for a moment, her words lingering in my mind. Maybe she was right. Maybe it was time to stop running in circles and start confronting the truth—no matter how messy it might be.

I took the rear staircase to exit out the rear of the building. The cold air hit me as I pushed open the back door of the office, the metal handle icy against my palm. Helen's words lingered in my mind as I made my way toward the car park. I'd fucked up, badly. The anger, the frustration—it had all boiled over, and now I was standing on the precipice of losing my job. Helen was right; I needed to get my head on straight. But where the hell was I supposed to start?

Pulling my phone from my pocket, I dialled Emmie's number, my thumb hesitating for a second before pressing the call button. The line rang and rang, each tone stretching my nerves tighter. Then her voicemail kicked in.

"Hey, it's me," I said, trying to sound calm despite the chaos in my chest. "Call me back when you get this. We need to talk."

I ended the call and stuffed the phone back into my pocket, heading toward my car. My steps echoed in the empty car park, my eyes scanning

the area automatically. The last thing I needed was to run into Mitch—or anyone else, for that matter. That was the reason I'd sneaked out of the back. But as I approached my car, I saw a figure leaning against the driver's side door, arms folded and head bowed slightly.

Sophie.

Her posture was tense, her normally playful expression replaced with something far more serious. As I drew closer, she straightened up, her kohl-lined brown eyes locking onto mine with an intensity that stopped me in my tracks.

"Hey," she said softly, her voice low and filled with genuine concern. "What the hell just happened in there, Ryan? Are you okay?"

"I screwed up," I sighed, running a hand through my hair. "I let Mitch get under my skin and now it looks like I'm in the shit unless Helen can smooth things out with Mitch."

"Fuck Mitch." Sophie looked away, her eyes unfocusing as she stared into the distance for a second. Then she turned back to me. "He's an asshole and deserved what he got. I'm proud of you."

"He made a move on Emmie while we were apart," I explained. "I may as well tell you before you hear it from someone else. I confronted him about it and... well, you know what happened after that."

Sophie ran a hand through her burgundy-dyed hair, pushing it back from her face. The platinum ring in her nose glinted in the light of the sun, which had managed to find a break in the heavy clouds above us.

"So this is what's been troubling you lately. Trouble with Emmie."

I didn't answer, which was answer enough.

Sophie exhaled sharply, shaking her head. "Of course. It's always Emmie, isn't it?"

"What's that supposed to mean?" I asked, frowning.

She didn't answer immediately. Instead, she turned away, staring out over the empty car park, folding her arms beneath her breasts, pushing them up. I saw a hint of her nipples poking through the thin material of her shirt, the shape of the bar piercing. "Ryan... can I ask you something? And I need you to be honest."

"Sure," I said cautiously.

"If Emmie had an affair with Mitch, who else was she involved with?" Sophie's voice was quiet, but the words hit me like a slap. "If she cheated

with him, who else has she fucked? Have you ever thought about that? She could have fucked anyone. People you know. Can you live with that?"

I opened my mouth to respond, but she cut me off, her gaze snapping back to mine. "I know my opinion doesn't matter to you. You're not asking for it and you don't want it but I'll tell you anyway. You're wasting your time, Ryan. She's not worth it."

"Sophie—"

"No, listen to me," she said, stepping closer again. Her pretty Mediterranean features took on an intensity I'd not seen before as she gazed at me. "I know you, Ryan. Better than you think. I've seen how much this is tearing you apart. You're not the kind of man who goes around punching people for no reason. And for what? A woman who's keeping secrets from you? A woman who's hurt you, lied to you? Fucked around without you knowing? You deserve better."

"Do I?" Sophie didn't know what I'd done. Sneaking around, trying to uncover Emmie's secrets. She didn't know that I'd fucked Laura.

Her voice softened, her beautiful brown eyes searching mine. "You deserve someone who won't hurt you. Someone who'll be honest with you. Someone who... who wants you for you. Sure, Emmie is beautiful. That blonde hair. That body. Those big boobs that everyone likes to stare at. But is she really who you think she is? No. You could do better. You really could."

I felt my breath catch as she placed a hand on my arm, her touch light but firm. "I've always liked you, Ryan. More than liked you. I have... feelings for you. I'd never lie to you, if you gave me a chance. And I know it's not the right time, but... maybe... this is a sign."

"A sign? Sophie, what are you talking about?" This wasn't the time. I couldn't deal with this right now.

"Emmie might be a good fuck," she continued, ignoring the question. "But I'll bet I'm better."

She moved, leaning into me so quickly that I didn't have the chance to step away. Her body pressed against mine, her lips seeking a kiss but I pulled my face away just in time.

"Just one date," she said, her voice trembling slightly, her breath warm on my cheek.

"Sophie, stop," I said, my voice barely above a whisper.

“One chance. If nothing else, at least promise me we’ll keep in touch when I leave.”

“Leave?” I asked, frowning, taking the chance to increase the distance between our two bodies before someone saw us. “Oh yeah, Helen mentioned it. You’re really leaving?”

She nodded, biting her lip. “I can’t stay here. Not after everything... Not with someone that I like, but who doesn’t like me in the same way.”

“What?” I mumbled. “I’m the reason you’re leaving?”

“Part of the reason.” She nodded, her fingers playing with one of the studs in her ear nervously. “But it’s not just you. It’s Mitch, Helen, everything... Plus, I’m setting up a new business. A fresh start, of sorts. Away from here.”

“You’re moving away?” As though I didn’t feel bad enough already, my lack of unreciprocated feelings for Sophie was causing her to change her job and move away.

Sophie licked her lips, glossy with dark purple lipstick, then looked away for a second, then back at me, her eyes finding mine. “But that doesn’t mean... that doesn’t mean we have to lose touch.”

Before I could respond, my phone buzzed in my pocket. I pulled it out, Emmie’s name flashing on the screen.

“Of course,” Sophie muttered, her voice tinged with bitterness. “She always knows when to get in the way.”

“I’ll just... I mean...” I hesitated, my thumb hovering over the answer button.

“It’s not like I’m pouring my heart to you or anything.” The sarcasm dripped from Sophie’s tongue. “It’s not like you can speak to Emmie anytime.”

“I need to tell her what’s happened,” I explained defensively.

“Of course you do.” Sophie stepped back, her expression shifting to one of resignation. “Go ahead,” she said, her voice quiet. “Answer it.”

I nodded, taking a few steps away before answering. “Emmie?”

“What’s going on, Ryan?” she demanded, her tone sharp. “Mitch just texted me. He said you punched him. Is that true?”

I pinched the bridge of my nose, glancing over at Sophie, who was watching me with an unreadable expression. “We need to talk,” I said finally. “Can we meet? Somewhere quiet? I’ll explain everything.”

“Fine,” Emmie said after a pause. “Where?”

“The park,” I said. “I need some fresh air. Meet me there in half an hour.”

“Alright,” she said, though her tone was wary. “I’ll see you there.”

I hung up, shoving the phone back into my pocket. Sophie was still standing by my car, her arms crossed tightly over the curves of her chest.

“Sophie...” I began, but she shook her head.

“Don’t bother,” she said, her voice tinged with sadness and something else... anger? “I get it. Emmie comes first. She always does.”

Before I could say another word, she turned and walked away, her shoulders stiff, her steps quick. I watched her go, guilt settling like a pit in my stomach.

I climbed into my car and sat there momentarily, my hands resting on the steering wheel. What had I done? I’d punched Mitch, told him what I knew. I’d even told him how I knew, implicated Laura even though I’d promised her I wouldn’t. I’d told T.J. and Sophie. I’d confided in Helen. I’d said too much. And to too many people. This would get to Emmie now. There was no stopping it. The cat was out of the bag.

But I had the opportunity to talk to her first. It was time. Time to tell her everything. I started the car.

Then my phone buzzed again. This time, it wasn’t a call. It was an email. The sender’s address was a throwaway, a random collection of letters and numbers, the subject line ominously blank. The paperclip symbol next to it showed an attachment.

I wanted to open it, read it, and check out whatever the mysterious emailer had sent me this time. But I didn’t. I tossed the phone back onto the passenger seat, put my hands on the wheel and pulled out of the car park. Whoever the person was that was sending me these emails, whoever it was that had sent me down this obsessive rabbit hole, they would have to wait.

I had to get to Emmie before someone else did. I had to talk to her, explain everything. I had to fix my marriage... before it was too late.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The park was quiet, save for the rustling of leaves underfoot and the distant sounds of life carrying on beyond its borders. The afternoon light bathed everything in a muted red glow, the setting sun dipping below the horizon. The air was cool, crisp with the promise of evening, and the smell of damp earth lingered in the air. Autumn leaves, fiery in their hues of crimson and gold, scattered across the paths, some catching in the faint breeze.

Then I saw her.

Emmie stood by a bench beneath a canopy of Sycamore trees, their leaves ablaze with colour. She wore her black leather jacket, the glossy material hugging her frame, over a red blouse that hinted at the curve of her bust and showed just the right amount of creamy cleavage. Her blonde hair shimmered in the fading light, catching in the slight wind. The colour red seemed to be everywhere—the leaves at her feet, the deep glow of the sunset behind her, and in my mind, the blood from Mitch’s split lip, bright, virulent red, flashed vividly, a stark memory of the mess I’d made of my life.

For a moment, she didn’t see me. She was scrolling through her phone, her face a mix of impatience and frustration. Then she looked up, her hazel eyes locking onto mine. Whatever warmth I hoped to find there was gone, replaced with cold anger.

I approached her slowly, the crunch of leaves under my boots breaking the silence between us. She crossed her arms, her leather jacket creaking slightly with the movement.

“Well?” she snapped, not even giving me the chance to start. “What the fuck, Ryan? You punched Mitch. Get explaining. And don’t bother lying. He told me everything.”

I cringed at her tone, sharp and laced with fury. “I lost my temper,” I admitted, trying to stay calm. “He—”

“Save it,” she cut me off, taking a step forward, her eyes blazing. “You know about me and him. He told me. What I want to know is who told you. Was it Mark? Or was it Laura?”

I blinked, caught off guard. “Emmie, that’s not—”

“Mitch said you told him our neighbour saw us.” Her voice rose, her words cutting through the crisp air like a blade. “So was it Laura, or was it Mark? What did they say, Ryan? Tell me. Tell me what they saw.”

“It doesn’t matter who told me,” I said, my voice growing firmer. “What matters is that you lied to me. You’ve been lying to me, Emmie. About Mitch. About Ethan. About everything.”

Her jaw tightened, her hands balling into fists at her sides. “I didn’t lie to you, Ryan. I just didn’t tell you because it’s none of your business. What I did while we were apart is *my* business, not yours.”

I felt the heat rising in my chest, my frustration bubbling over. “We were still married, Emmie. You sucked his cock. Maybe you fucked him. You *definitely* fucked Ethan... and God only knows who else. Does that mean nothing to you?”

“We were separated!” she shot back, her voice cracking. “Do you know how broken I was? Do you even care? I didn’t know if we’d ever get back together, and I was trying to move on. I made mistakes. So did you.”

“I didn’t fuck anyone! And this isn’t about me!” I shouted, my voice echoing across the empty park. “This is about you not being honest with me now. If we’re going to fix this, I need the truth, Emmie. All of it. Ethan. Mitch. Shaun. Who else has fucked my wife? Aren’t I entitled to know?”

She laughed bitterly, shaking her head. “Fix this? Do you think this is about fixing us? You’re obsessed, Ryan. You’re digging up the past, dragging other people into our business, punching people because you can’t control your jealousy. That’s not fixing anything. That’s destroying it.”

Her phone buzzed, and she pulled it out, glancing at the screen. The anger visibly drained from her. “It’s Jen,” she muttered, suddenly subdued. “She needs me.”

“Emmie—” I started, but she held up a hand, silencing me.

“I’m done with this conversation,” she said coldly, slipping her phone back into her pocket. “Maybe we made a mistake trying to make this work. If you can’t move past what I did when I was single, if you’re someone who goes around making assumptions and punching people, then maybe you’re not the man I thought you were.”

“I am the man you thought I was,” I called after her. “Emmie, stop. Please. Don’t go. Jen can wait.”

“No, she can’t.” Emmie shook her head. “Jen’s got her own issues, Ryan. Big issues. The difference is that she doesn’t go around punching people to fix them. My sister needs me. We can talk later.”

She turned and walked away, her boots crunching over the leaves, her blonde hair catching the last rays of the sun as she disappeared down the path. I stood there, my chest tight, my mind racing. I had to fix this. Somehow.

My phone buzzed in my pocket. For a moment, I thought it might be Emmie, but it wasn’t. It was an email. The same random address, the same blank subject line.

My heart sank. Now really wasn’t the time for this. I opened the email, ignoring the first so I wouldn’t be tempted to look at the attachment.

Ryan, it read. I’m waiting for a reply. This has to happen. Tonight.

What has to happen? Why now? Had the fight in the office triggered something? If so, that would narrow it down to just a few people, those who knew about me punching Mitch and why. I fought the temptation to open the first email, to see what it said.

No, I thought to myself. You’re not in control of me. I’m going to ignore you and reply in my own time. When it’s convenient to me. Emmie knows that I know. I’m the one in control now.

I shoved the phone back into my pocket, my mind a storm of anger and confusion. The emailer’s timing couldn’t have been worse. First Mitch, then Emmie, and now this. Every thread of my life that had felt tangled, knotted beyond repair, had suddenly unravelled, leaving everything in a messy heap. I kicked my way through the fallen leaves as I hurried to my car, my head still spinning from the fight with Emmie. Sliding into the driver’s seat,

I took a deep breath and pulled out my phone. First things first: Luke. He needed to know how deep in this mess I was. He'd be able to help. He'd been in tricky situations before, if not quite as complicated as this. Even so, I needed advice, so I fired off a quick text:

Need your help, mate. Things are bad. Call me when you can.

With that done, I hesitated, then dialled Laura. The line rang and rang, each buzz adding to the anxiety burning in my gut. Finally, her voicemail clicked on. I ended the call without leaving a message. She had to call me back soon. She just had to. If Mitch had mentioned her to Emmie, it meant the fragile wall I'd built to protect her was crumbling. She deserved a heads-up.

As I drove home, the streets blurred past, bathed in the soft glow of streetlights flickering to life. My mind was racing with too many thoughts, none of them productive. Was Emmie already telling Jen everything? The uneasy silence of my car felt oppressive, the unanswered questions pounding like a drumbeat in my skull.

I pulled into my driveway, cutting the engine and stepping out into the cold evening air. My house loomed ahead, dark and silent. No sign of Emmie's car. I glanced next door at Laura's house, her front window dark, her driveway empty. *Fuck*. Where was she? Did she know what was happening?

Ignoring the creeping dread in my stomach, I knocked on Laura's door, the sound echoing hollowly in the stillness. No answer. I knocked again, harder this time. Nothing. I pulled out my phone, sending her a quick text:

Laura, call me. It's urgent.

I waited a few more moments, pacing her porch like an idiot, then gave up and returned to my own house. The silence inside was deafening, the emptiness almost mocking. I tossed my keys onto the kitchen counter and sat down heavily at the dining table, burying my face in my hands. What was I supposed to do now? Emmie was furious, Laura was missing, and the emailer was pushing for something I didn't understand.

My phone buzzed again and I pulled it out of my pocket. Another email. This one had a subject line.

Don't ignore me. You'll regret it.

My pulse quickened as I opened it, my breath catching at the words inside.

You're in the endgame now, whether you like it or not. Time is running out.

I stared at the screen, my hands trembling. The emailer's taunting felt more personal this time, almost like a challenge. What was in the first email that was so important? Why were they being so insistent?

Against my better judgment, I tapped back into my inbox and clicked on the first email.

Look at the attachment. I have all the videos. It's time we met. Meet me tonight and you can have everything. You can know everything. For a price.

Blackmail. This was blackmail. I felt nauseous and had to set the phone down for a moment while I took a deep breath. Then, when the sickness subsided, I picked it back up. The attachment was there, taunting me, daring me to open it. I clicked on it. It opened, filling the screen.

It was a single image but comprised of four thumbnails. My heart skipped a beat as I zoomed in, recognising the first immediately. It was from the video I'd already seen of Emmie, of her on her back, masturbating for the cameraman and whoever else was there. I moved to the second thumbnail and a cold feeling shot through my veins. Emmie was there again, naked, her beautiful breasts hanging in front of her as she knelt on a carpeted floor. Next to her, the bottom half of a naked man was in view. A black man. My breath hitched in my throat as I looked at the size of his cock, huge and thick, standing to attention in front of my wife's face.

Emmie, you fucked a black guy? I couldn't believe what I was seeing. And who the fuck had videoed it?

I scanned down to the next thumbnail, dread settling in my stomach.

But the third thumbnail was different. It wasn't Emmie.

It was Jen.

I stared at it, my mind struggling to process what I was seeing. It was her face, unmistakably her, caught in the glow of a camera's flash. She was naked, her straight blonde hair flowing over her pert breasts, her nipples protruding through, pink and small. A neat landing strip of light brown hair was between her long, bare legs, parted for the camera, showing everything. I pinched two fingers on the screen, pushing them apart to zoom in.

Fuck. I could see everything. *Everything.* I shouldn't be looking but I couldn't help it. Her body was slimmer than Emmie's, her tits smaller but she was still hot. I'd occasionally wondered what she looked like naked. Now I knew and I wasn't disappointed.

Even so... Jen. My sister-in-law. How the hell was she involved in this?

I moved to the fourth and final thumbnail but this one was the least interesting. It only showed a hand — a female hand — tightly gripping what looked like bed sheets. It could have been Emmie's hand or Jen's hand, it was hard to tell. But whoever it was, the thumbnail suggested they were in the throes of passion.

I clenched my jaw, my pulse pounding in my ears. This wasn't just about me anymore. This was bigger than I'd imagined, and I needed answers. My fingers hovered over the reply button, but I hesitated. No. I wouldn't let them dictate the terms. Not yet. Not until I understood what was at stake.

I grabbed my keys again, my thoughts racing. If Laura wasn't home, there was only one other person I could turn to. Luke. My hands trembled as I tried to call him, typed another text when he didn't pick up. Where the fuck was everyone when I needed them?

Luke, seriously. Call me back ASAP. It's about Emmie and Jen. I'm in something way over my head.

With that, I stepped back outside, the chill biting into my skin as I locked the door behind me. My phone buzzed again. Another email.

Ryan. Don't keep me waiting. Ignoring me is a mistake.

I finally started typing, my cold, almost numb fingers trembling slightly.

What do you want?

The reply came almost instantly, as if the sender had been waiting.

Finally. Meet me at The Dolphin. There's an alley behind the car park. One hour. Come alone, that's all I ask and we'll discuss the deal.

A deal for the videos. For Emmie's—and Jen's—secrets. But what kind of deal? My legs felt weak. My chest tightened, my heart hammering at the implications, but I couldn't ignore the emailer any longer. This was my chance to get the answers I needed, to finally understand the full scope of whatever had happened during our separation, to put an end to all of this. And yet, a sense of foreboding settled over me.

I typed my reply quickly.

I'll be there. But if this is a waste of time, you'll regret it.

The response was immediate.

You've already wasted enough of my time, Ryan. Don't be late.

I shoved the phone into my pocket, my mind racing. I had an hour. Enough time to try to sort through the chaos in my head. I needed to know

where Emmie had gone and make sure Laura was safe before I left for the meeting. I dialled Emmie's number first, but it went straight to voicemail.

"Emmie, it's me," I said, keeping my tone calm despite the frustration bubbling beneath the surface. "Please call me when you get this. We need to finish our conversation. I know you're with Jen, but I... I just need to talk to you." I paused. "I love you. Whatever happened, I'm ready to forgive you. Please, just call me."

I ended the call and exhaled sharply. Turning, I glanced toward Laura's house. The lights were still off but maybe she was home now. I needed to check and warn her. She might be caught up in this, too. I got out of the car and crossed the garden, my footsteps crunching against the damp grass. I looked through the darkened windows but couldn't see anyone. I rang the doorbell anyway, waited, then knocked. Nothing.

"Damn it," I muttered under my breath.

I pulled out my phone and shot her another text.

Laura, call me when you get this. It's urgent. I need to talk to you. I've dropped you in it with Emmie. I'm sorry. Just call me.

With no response from either Emmie or Laura, I went back to my car. My mind was a storm of emotions—anger at Mitch, confusion about Emmie, fear of what the emailer had in store. The clock on the dashboard read 7:15 PM. I had just enough time to get to The Dolphin.

I recalled following Emmie to the restaurant last week, remembering the layout but I couldn't picture the alleyway. An imagined version of it loomed in my mind like a scene from a crime thriller. Dark, secluded, and perfect for shady dealings. The hairs on the back of my neck stood up as I imagined what—or who—might be waiting for me there.

Stop being such a pussy, Ryan. Be a man. It was Emmie's voice, encouraging me in my head.

I checked my phone one last time before starting the engine. No new messages, no missed calls. Just me, and whatever waited in that alley. I drove off, the streetlights casting eerie shadows on the road as the last of the day's light faded. Whatever happened tonight, I wasn't leaving without answers.

The streets were quiet as I approached The Dolphin. The former pub's cheerful facade, lit with fairy lights, clashed against the dark shadow of the alleyway that I now noticed behind it. I parked a short distance away, my

hands tightening on the steering wheel as I sat for a moment, staring at the dimly lit car park.

The alley was nothing like I'd imagined—narrow, bordered by brick walls with faded graffiti, and littered with discarded bottles and crumpled cigarette packets. Still, it seemed like the perfect spot for an ambush. My gut churned as I turned off the engine and climbed out of the car, the cool night air biting at my skin.

I checked my phone. 7:58 PM. Two minutes to spare.

I stepped carefully across the busy car park, toward the alley, every sense on high alert. The silence was oppressive, broken only by the distant street noises and then the hoot of an owl made me jump, cursing under my breath. My heart pounded as I regathered my composure and rounded the corner, the dim glow of a single streetlight casting a lengthened shadow of myself on the littered, mossy ground in front of me.

Then I saw her.

The emailer stood waiting near the wall, her back to me, hood pulled up against the night's chill and shrouded in shadow. Her silhouette defined her as female, tallish, slim, curvy hips. Her posture was tense, her hands shoved into her pockets. She wasn't moving, just staring at the ground, her presence unsettlingly still.

"Hello," I called, my voice echoing slightly in the confined space. "It's me. I'm here."

She turned slowly, gazing at me from beneath the darkness of her hood. I couldn't see who it was.

Then, after the longest moment of my life, she reached up, lowering her hood to reveal her face. My breath caught in my throat.

"Jen?" I took a hesitant step closer, confusion rippling through me. "What the fuck?"

Her face was pale, her lips pressed into a thin line. "Ryan?" she said, her voice trembling slightly. "What are *you* doing here?"

"I'm here to meet—" I stopped mid-sentence, my mind reeling. "Wait. Are *you* the emailer?"

Her eyes widened in shock, and she took a step back. "What? No! I thought..." She trailed off, her expression shifting to one of confusion and fear. "Are you? Wait. This makes no sense."

The pieces began to fall into place, each one more damning than the last. "You've been getting emails too," I guessed, my voice barely above a

whisper.

She nodded, her shoulders sagging as she let out a shaky breath. “They’ve been threatening me. Blackmailing me. Saying they’d expose everything if I didn’t pay up. They told me to meet here first. Said we could talk.”

My legs almost gave way beneath me. I’d been tricked. Set up. But why?

“Expose what, Jen? What are they holding over you?”

Her face crumpled, and she looked away, tears pooling in her eyes. “Not here,” she muttered. “I can’t...”

Before I could press her further, the sound of an engine broke the silence. A car sped past the alley’s entrance, its headlights briefly illuminating the shadows around us, blinding me for a second. Jen gasped, her eyes widening in alarm.

“No,” she whispered, taking off toward the car park. I chased after her as she broke into a run, following close behind, my heart hammering in my chest.

As we reached the car park, my stomach dropped. Jen’s car was there, I hadn’t noticed it among all of the other vehicles, but the passenger window had been smashed, glass littering the asphalt, glimmering in the fairy lights of the pub close by. The driver’s side door was slightly ajar, and the interior light cast a pale glow over the chaos inside.

“They’ve taken it,” Jen said, her voice cracking as she stumbled toward the car. She peered inside, her hands shaking as she clutched the door. “The money... I brought the money, and they’ve taken it.”

I was a decoy. A pawn in an intricate game of blackmail chess. I couldn’t believe it. Was any of this even about me? Or was it all about Jen?

Then I froze, my eyes darting to the seat. There, lying on the leather, was a bright red USB stick with a single post-it note attached. The handwriting was neat, the message almost mocking.

To Ryan. The deal is done. Thank you. Enjoy the videos and photos.

Jen turned to me, her face ashen, tears rolling down her mascara-streaked cheeks. “Ryan... what the fuck is going on?”

I had no answers. Only questions. Too many questions. But I was going to find the answers if it was the last thing I ever did.

AFTERWORD

As this penultimate book ends, Ryan has learned so much but is left grappling with more unanswered questions. What is going on with Jen and how much more is she keeping from him? Who is the blackmailer and how far will Ryan go to get to the heart of the secrets that threaten his marriage? And most importantly, what will happen when he finally uncovers the full extent of Emmie's past?

I have to send out a thanks to my author friend, Kenny Wright, for helping me edit and supporting and encouraging me along the way. You should absolutely check out his hotwife erotica on Amazon, if you haven't already.

Thank you so much for buying and reading this book. Your support means the world. The tension is far from over, and the answers you're waiting for will come soon in Book 4, where everything will be revealed—and the journey to the truth will finally reach its shocking conclusion. Stay tuned for the next chapter in Ryan and Emmie's story!

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ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Paul Garland is an author of erotic novels and short stories, guaranteed to keep you turning the lust-filled pages until the early hours of the night. He lives with his wife and two children in a small house in the suburbs of Sheffield, England along with a lazy green budgerigar, an African Grey parrot that curses and a tubby tabby cat which would love to eat either. (Preferably the vulgar-tongued parrot.)

He has been writing since the turn of the millennium but only turned to the erotica genre in 2018 with his *Cerulean Erotica Presents* series and *No Angels* series of books which rapidly gained him a following. In 2020, he began 'The Cuckold Collection,' a brand new collection of cuckold-themed books and two new series of shorter stories: *The No Angels Stories*, *The Sexy Season Stories* and *The Cerulean Archives*. 2022 began two series, *Holiday Hotwives* and *A Size Queen Story* and 2023 introduced a new series, *Improper Investigations* and the return to the *Cerulean Archives* with *I Found A Box Of Photos Of My Wife... And Her Ex*. 2024 sees another new series along with continuations of his current running series, the *My Wife* series and the return of *The Detective Hotwife*.

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